Disentangling syntactic ergativity from constraints on ergative displacement

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Abstract. A subset of morphologically ergative languages have been claimed to display syntactic rules which are sensitive to the distinction between ergative and absolutive arguments—syntactic ergativity. The most robustly attested syntactic ergativity effect concerns the accessibility of the ergative argument for displacement (relativization, topicalization, focus fronting, question formation, etc.). Researchers have explicitly or implicitly assumed that there are no syntactically ergative languages which do not display a constraint on ergative displacement, and as a result, the term SYNTACTIC ERGATIVITY has largely come to be synonymous with this constraint. Using data from West Circassian (Northwest Caucasian) and Samoan (Polynesian), this paper challenges this position on two counts. Firstly, it argues that a universal correlation between syntactic ergativity and a ban on ergative displacement is theoretically unexpected and empirically incorrect. Secondly, it challenges the utility of contrasts in morphological exponence as a metric for determining the presence of syntactic ergativity in displacement dependencies.

Keywords: relativization, focus fronting, ergativity, reciprocal, parasitic gaps, crossover effects, syntactic islands, resumptive, West Circassian, Samoan

1. INTRODUCTION.

A subset of languages which display ergative-absolutive alignment in the morphology have been claimed to display some degree of ergativity in the syntax as well.[1] Since at least Dixon 1994; Kazenin 1994; Bittner and Hale 1996; Manning 1996, the trademark property of a syntactically ergative language has been taken to be a contrast in accessibility for relativization, focus fronting, wh-question formation or other types of displacement: absolutive, but not ergative, arguments may be displaced. Subsequent work has overwhelmingly taken accessibility for extraction to be the litmus test for determining whether a language should be labeled as syntactically ergative, and the term SYNTACTIC ERGATIVITY has largely come to be equated with the constraint on ergative displacement (see e.g. Aldridge 2004, 2008; Coon, Mateo, and Preminger 2014; Coon, Baier, and Levin 2021; Deal 2016; Polinsky 2016, 2017; Tollan 2021; Tollan and Clemens 2022; Yuan 2022; Drummond 2023; Branan and Erlewine 2024; Brodkin and Royer 2024). Furthermore, the constraint on ergative displacement is overwhelmingly diagnosed by appealing to the presence

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of additional morphology in ergative displacement configurations, which is absent when other arguments are displaced. For example, obligatory resumption with ergative relativization (and other types of fronting) in Tongan (1a; cf. absolutive displacement with a gap in 1b) has been taken as sufficient evidence that the ergative argument is unable to undergo syntactic displacement (Otsuka 2006; Polinsky 2016, 2017).[2]

(1) a.

e	faiako$_i$	[‘oku	*(ne$_i$)	ako‘i	‘a	e	leo	faka-Tonga]
DET	teacher	PRS	3SG.CL	teach	ABS	DET	language	Tongan

‘the teacher who is teaching/teaches the Tongan language’

b.

e	‘anga$_i$	[‘oku	(*ne$_i$)	muimui	‘i	he	vaka]
DET	shark	PRS	3SG.CL	follow	LOC	DET	boat

‘the shark that is following the boat’ (Tongan; Polinsky 2016:236-237)

While other syntactic ergativity effects have been occasionally discussed, such as pro-drop in coordinate structures and the ability to be controlled PRO (Dixon 1994; Aldridge 2004, 2008; Deal 2016),[3] these have been claimed to appear only in languages which also display the constraint on ergative extraction, leading to an implicational hierarchy: if a language is to display any syntactic ergativity effect, it will display the constraint on ergative displacement (Kazenin 1994; Aldridge 2008; Deal 2016).

A robust line of research has argued that the constraint on ergative extraction arises as a consequence of a syntactically ergative clause structure, wherein the absolutive theme moves to a higher position that the ergative, effectively trapping the ergative in its base position (Bittner and Hale 1996; Aldridge 2004, 2008, 2012; Coon, Mateo, and Preminger 2014; Coon, Baier, and Levin 2021; Tollan and Clemens 2022; Yuan 2022; Branan and Erlewine 2024; Brodkin and Royer 2024). This type of HIGH ABSOLUTIVE—in Coon, Mateo, and Preminger's (2014) terms—clause structure is then expected to tightly correlate with the unavailability of ergative extraction: if a language has high absolutive syntax, it will also display syntactic ergativity in configurations involving the displacement of the ergative argument.

This paper challenges the existing view of syntactic ergativity from two angles. On the one hand, I argue that the implicational hierarchy which equates syntactically ergative syntax with a ban on ergative displacement is empirically incorrect: West Circassian, a Northwest Caucasian language, displays syntactic ergativity in a number of domains including anaphor binding (Ershova

[2] In more recent work Otsuka (2017) departs from the connection between resumption and a ban on extraction by analyzing the resumptive pronoun which appears with ergative displacement as the spellout of a lower copy in a movement configuration.

[3] See Legate 2008a for an alternative assessment of the evidence from Dyirbal, which has been a primary example of a language displaying multiple syntactic ergativity effects.

2023b), parasitic gap licensing (Ershova 2021), and subextraction asymmetries (Ershova 2024), but it does not display a ban on ergative extraction. This suggests that high absolutive syntax should not be necessarily associated with a restriction on ergative movement. On the other hand, I demonstrate that this is an entirely desirable conclusion for syntactic theory: there is nothing that intrinsically derives the ban on ergative displacement from high absolutive syntax, and indeed, existing analyses in this vein allow parametric space for high absolutive languages which do not display this restriction.

Finally, I address the efficacy of appealing to morphological exponence as a diagnostic for syntactic ergativity. In West Circassian, relativization of the ergative involves an overt relativizing prefix, whereas there is no comparable specialized morphology in cases of absolutive relativization (Lander 2009a, 2012b; Lander and Daniel 2019). Despite a contrast in morphological exponence, both ergatives and absolutives are equally accessible for relativization and correspondingly pass typical diagnostics for displacement dependencies such as island sensitivity, parasitic gap licensing, and crossover effects. I demonstrate the same point for Samoan, which has similarly been claimed to display syntactic ergativity based on the appearance of a verbal suffix in cases of ergative displacement (Polinsky 2016; Hopperdietzel 2020; Hopperdietzel and Alexiadou 2024, 2025): as in West Circassian, the appearance of this additional morpheme, while clearly demonstrating that ergative extraction has an effect on the surface morphosyntax, is not a reliable diagnostic for the inability of the ergative argument to move. I demonstrate that the displacement of the ergative argument passes typical movement diagnostics analogously to the absolutive, and that the suffix which appears in ergative displacement configurations, while connected to ergativity by virtue of spelling out the head which introduces ergative external arguments, is not a direct reflex of displacement, but rather a consequence of more general morphophonological constraints on exponence and affixation.

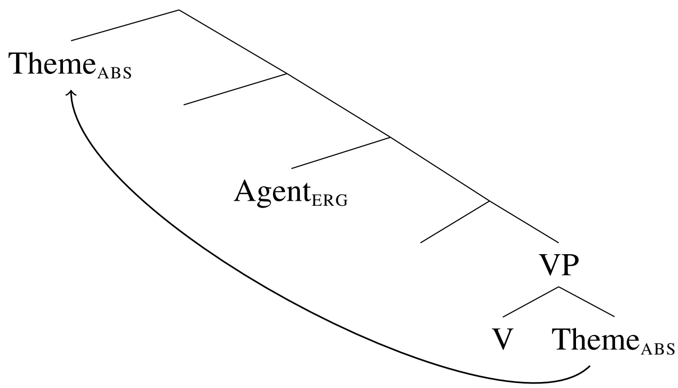
The imperfect correlation between the appearance of additional morphology and a bone fide ban on ergative extraction suggests that the former should not be considered a syntactic ergativity effect without additional structural diagnostics. Furthermore, the possibility of high absolutive syntax without any effect on ergative movement suggests that syntactic ergativity should not be equated with the ban on ergative extraction and syntactically ergative languages should not be expected to universally display the corresponding constraint. The term syntactic ergativity would then be better utilized to refer to an underlyingly ergative clause structure wherein the absolutive argument occupies a structurally privileged, subject-like position.

The rest of the paper is structured as follows: §2 discusses the connection between high absolutive syntax and syntactic ergativity; §3 presents evidence from West Circassian that syntactic ergativity does not necessarily correlate with a ban on ergative extraction; §4 explores the connection between additional overt morphology associated with ergative displacement and syntactic constraints on movement through the prism of Samoan, and §5 concludes.

2. THE CONNECTION BETWEEN SYNTACTIC ERGATIVITY AND HIGH ABSOLUTIVE SYNTAX. There are broadly two strands of approaches to accounting for syntactic ergativity in the narrow sense, i.e. the ban on ergative displacement (see Deal 2016; Polinsky 2017 for a comprehensive overview). One line of research derives the impossibility of ergative extraction from the morphosyntactic properties of the ergative argument, such as its case marking (Otsuka 2006; Legate 2012; Deal 2016) or its status as an adpositional phrase (Polinsky 2016). Under this approach, ergativity effects in the syntax (in this case—in displacement dependencies) do not correlate with an underlyingly ergative syntax: languages which display syntactic ergativity have the same basic clause structure, thematic relations and argument asymmetries as nominative-accusative languages.

The other line of research argues that syntactic ergativity effects arise as a consequence of the absolutive argument occupying a position that is structurally higher than the ergative—in effect, a syntactically ergative clause structure. With the exception of early proposals in Levin 1983; Marantz 1984, this high position of the absolutive is taken to be derived, at least in transitive clauses, where the corresponding argument is merged VP-internally as a theme and subsequently moves to a position above the ergative external argument (2) (Bittner 1994; Bittner and Hale 1996; Aldridge 2004, 2008, 2012; Coon, Mateo, and Preminger 2014; Coon, Baier, and Levin 2021; Tollan 2021; Tollan and Clemens 2022; Yuan 2022; Brodkin and Royer 2024). This derived status of the absolutive argument reconciles high absolutive analyses with standard assumptions about the universal correlation between thematic roles and syntactic positions—formalized, for example, as the Uniformity of Theta Assignment Hypothesis (Baker 1988, 1997)—as well as the observation that the ergative argument generally continues to display typical subjecthood properties, such as the ability to bind anaphors, be controlled PRO or denote the addressee in imperatives (see e.g. Anderson 1976 and Dixon 1994:111-142 on universal subjecthood properties of the ergative).

(2)



In addition to the ban on ergative extraction, high absolutive syntax has been taken to correlate with definiteness restrictions and obligatory wide scope for the absolutive argument (see Bittner 1994; Bittner and Hale 1996; Yuan 2022 on Inuit and Aldridge 2004, 2008, 2012 on Tagalog and Seediq).[4] In Mayan languages, high absolutive syntax has also been associated with high absolutive agreement (Coon, Mateo, and Preminger 2014; Coon, Baier, and Levin 2021), obviation of Condition C effects (Royer 2025), and the unavailability of absolutive case in nominalizations (Royer and Coon 2025).

In the remainder of this section I argue that, while the connection between high absolutive syntax and the constraint on ergative extraction appears to be present in some languages, these analyses rely on the interaction between high absolutive syntax and another, unrelated syntactic parameter. Furthermore, these analyses do not derive the implicational hierarchy proposed by Kazenin (1994); Aldridge (2008); Deal (2016) which states that if a language will display any syntactic ergativity effects, it will display a ban on ergative extraction: a derivation involving a high position for the absolutive argument does not and cannot universally block ergative displacement. Despite appearing to be a drawback of these analyses, the following section presents evidence that a dissociation between high absolutive syntax and a ban on ergative displacement is a welcome result: the universal correlation between syntactic ergativity and constraints on ergative displacement is empirically incorrect.

[4] Tagalog, Seediq and a number of other Austonesian languages display what is typologically termed symmetrical or Philippine-type voice, where any core argument may be morphosyntactically privileged through specialized marking on the argument itself and co-varying morphology on the predicate (see e.g. Himmelmann 2005; Blust 2013). Subjecthood properties are distributed between this privileged argument and the highest thematic argument (e.g. the agent of a transitive verb), similarly to the distribution of subject-like properties between the ergative and absolutive arguments in high absolutive languages (see Manning 1996 for extensive discussion of parallels between these alignment types). There is a rich tradition of literature on symmetrical voice systems which does not analyze them as ergative; see e.g. Schachter (1976, 1977); Guilfoyle et al. (1992); Kroeger (1993); Rackowski (2002); Rackowski and Richards (2005); van Urk (2015); Erlewine et al. (2017); Chen (2017, 2025); Chen and McDonnell (2019); Erlewine and Lim (2023).

I focus on two types of proposals which connect high absolutive syntax with the constraint on ergative extraction: (i) an intervention-based approach, wherein the absolutive argument blocks ergative displacement by virtue of its higher position (Coon, Baier, and Levin 2021—henceforth CBL2021; see also Aldridge 2004, 2008, 2012; Branan and Erlewine 2024) and (ii) an analysis which appeals to the grammaticalization of a processing constraint against crossing dependencies, thus ruling out the movement of the ergative agent because it would cross the movement dependency between the high and low positions of the absolutive argument (Tollan and Clemens 2022—henceforth TC2022).

The evidence for both CBL2021 and TC2022 comes from Mayan languages, a subset of which do not allow displacement of the ergative agent with a gap, in contrast to absolutive arguments. For example, focus constructions in K'iche' involve the fronting of the focused constituent to preverbal position (the unmarked word order is VOS). While both an absolutive subject of an intransitive verb (3a) and an absolutive internal argument of a transitive verb (3b) may be focus fronted with a gap, an ergative agent may not (3c).

(3) a. Aree le al Mari'y x-tze'n-ik $\_\__i$.
FOC DET HON Maria CPL-laugh-SS
'[Maria]$_{\text{FOC}}$ laughed.'

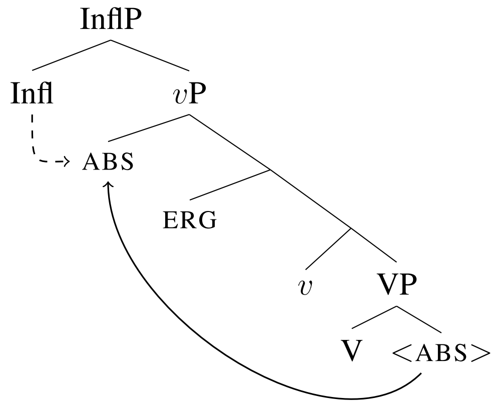
b. Aree le ichaj$_i$ k-Ø-u-tij $\_\__i$ le al Mari'y.
FOC DET vegetables INCL-3SG.ABS-3SG.ERG-eat:TV DET HON Maria
'Maria will eat [the vegetables]$_{\text{FOC}}$.'

c. * Aree le al Mari'y$_i$ k-Ø-u-tij le ichaj $\_\__i$.
FOC DET HON Maria INCL-3SG.ABS-3SG.ERG-eat:TV DET vegetables
Intended: '[Maria]$_{\text{FOC}}$ will eat the vegetables.' (K'iche'; Tollan and Clemens 2022:466)

In the Mayan languages, the impossibility of ergative displacement with a gap broadly correlates with the position of absolutive agreement (originally observed by Tada 1993): in languages which disallow ergative displacement absolutive agreement appears to the left of the verbal stem, whereas in languages which do not display extraction asymmetries absolutive agreement is exponed postverbally. Following Coon, Mateo, and Preminger (2014), both CBL2021 and TC2022 connect the position of the absolutive agreement marker to the position of the corresponding argument: if the agreement is to the left of the verb, the absolutive argument moves to a position that is local enough for agreement with Infl^0 (4a). On the other hand, if the agreement is low, the absolutive argument remains VP-internal and agrees with v^0 (4b).[5]

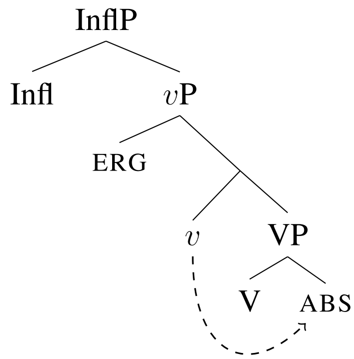
[5]The two accounts differ in assumptions about the landing site of the high absolutive argument: CBL2021 propose that the absolutive object moves to outer Spec,vP whereas Tollan and Clemens (2022) place the derived position in Spec,ssP (a projection associated with the status suffix). Earlier work within this tradition has associated the absolutive

(4) a. High absolutive



argument with a higher position in Spec,InflP (Campana 1992) or Spec,AspP (Ordóñez 1995). The uniting intuition in all these accounts is that the absolutive argument moves to a position above the ergative external argument.

b. Low absolutive



Focus fronting of a transitive subject triggers specialized morphology on the verb: the so-called agent focus suffix, which is accompanied by an intransitive status suffix and the absence of the ergative cross-reference prefix (5).

(5)

Aree	ri	a	Xwaan$_i$	x-in-to'w-ik	__$_i$.
FOC	DET	CL	Juan	CPL-1SG.ABS-help:AF-SS	

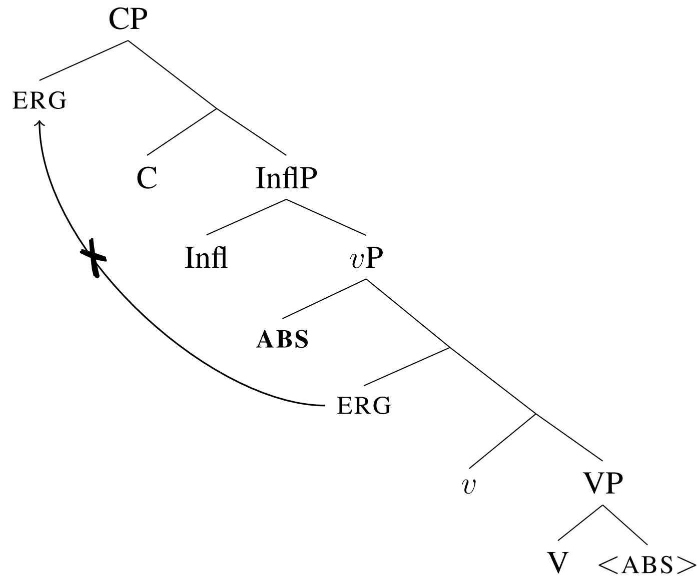
'[Juan]$_{FOC}$ helped (me).' (K'iche'; Velleman 2014:21 *via* Tollan and Clemens 2022:466)

Under a high absolutive analysis, agent focus involves a derivation which exceptionally allows the internal argument to remain low, either because it detransitivizes the predicate and licenses the object in situ, akin to an antipassive (Aissen 2011; Coon, Mateo, and Preminger 2014; Tollan and Clemens 2022), or simply lacks the feature which would trigger the raising of the absolutive argument (CBL2021).[6]

The constraint on ergative extraction thus arises in cases of high absolutive syntax: if the absolutive argument moves to a position above the ergative, the ergative argument cannot then undergo subsequent Ā-movement (6).

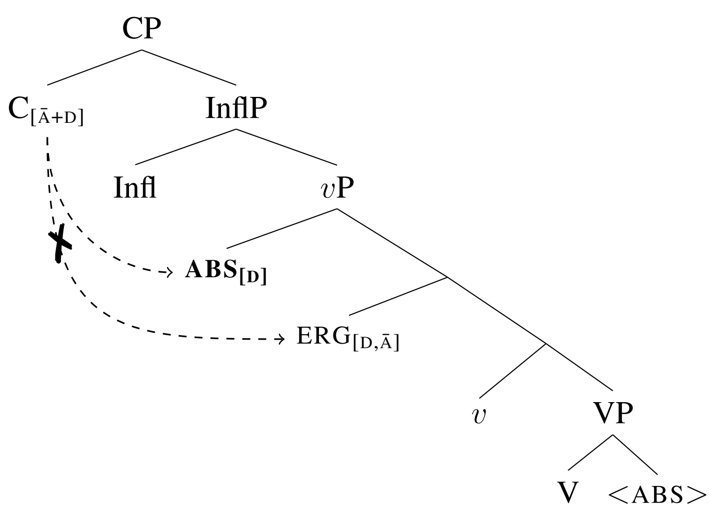
[6]An alternative approach to the displacement restrictions in Mayan is to treat agent focus as a morphosyntactic reflex of ergative displacement (Stiebels 2006; Erlewine 2016; Newman 2024)—under these accounts, the displaced constituent in 5 is still ergative case-marked and there is no high absolutive syntax. This is very similar in spirit to what this paper argues regarding ergative displacement in Samoan (§4), but see Royer and Coon (2025) for critical discussion of such approaches for Mayan.

(6) The high absolutive intervenes for extraction of the ergative:



CBL2021 derive this blocking effect by appealing to intervention: in Mayan languages with high absolutive syntax, C^0 hosts a relativized Ā-probe which is "bundled to search for [Ā] and [D] features" (CBL2021:287). The absolutive argument then, by virtue of bearing a [D] feature, will intervene between the Ā-probe on C^0 and the lower ergative DP—this is represented in simplified form in 7.

(7)



This type of relativized Ā-probe generates a language which only allows the highest DP to Ā-move and versions of this account have been used to explain pivot-only extraction restrictions in Austronesian languages (Aldridge 2008, 2012). Under this account, the ban on ergative extraction is derived from a combination of two ingredients: (i) raising of the absolutive argument to a position above the ergative and (ii) an Ā-probe that is relativized to search for both an Ā-feature and a D-feature. Since there appears to be no logical connection between these two parameters, we might expect to find languages which display one of these, but not the other. Regarding the relativized Ā-probe, Branan and Erlewine (2024) have indeed argued that it is attested in a small set of nominative-accusative languages.[7] By extension, one might also expect to find a language which displays high absolutive syntax but has a generalized Ā-probe.[8] Thus, if the ban on ergative extraction is a fundamental property of syntactically ergative systems, this connection remains wholly mysterious under this analysis: whether there is a movement-triggering feature on v^0 cannot influence whether a language has a relativized Ā-probe on C^0.

TC2022 similarly derive the ban on ergative extraction from the high position of the absolutive DP. However, instead of appealing to a relativized Ā-probe, they attribute the ungrammaticality of ergative extraction over the derived position of the absolutive argument to a violation of a Constraint on Crossing Dependencies: "no movement dependency may cross another movement dependency" (TC2022:469). As the authors discuss, this constraint reflects a general tendency for languages to prefer nesting dependencies (8a) to crossing dependencies (8b), and processing and production studies indeed confirm that nesting dependencies are considerably more common cross-linguistically (see references in TC2022:471).

(8) a. Nesting dependency

Filler$_i$ Filler$_j$ Gap$_j$ Gap$_i$

b. Crossing dependency

Filler$_i$ Filler$_j$ Gap$_i$ Gap$_j$

English, for example, disallows crossing dependencies in configurations which involve wh-fronting and tough-movement (9a), whereas nesting dependencies are perfectly licit (9b).

[7] Although see Newman 2023 for arguments that the data in Branan and Erlewine 2024 involves A-movement, rather than Ā-movement.

[8] A reviewer correctly points out that Inuit, which has been argued to display high absolutive syntax (Bittner 1994; Bittner and Hale 1996; Yuan 2018, 2022), might be an example of such a system: the ergative argument may not be relativized, but no such constraint applies in other types of displacement dependencies (Yuan 2022:fn.13; Deal et al. 2024). Similar observations have been made for Kaqchikel (Heaton et al. 2016) and Tagalog (Pizarro-Guevara and Wagers 2020, 2024), which ban ergative wh-movement, but allow for other types of ergative displacement (to the extent that 'ergative' is the appropriate term for Tagalog; see fn.3). With the present discussion in mind, this could be explained by positing a relativized Ā-probe for the type of displacement which displays syntactic ergativity, but a generalized Ā-probe for other types of extraction. Indeed, the analysis proposed by Deal et al. (2024) for Kalaallisut appeals to variation in relativized probing, but the authors argue that Inuit does not have high absolutive syntax, and the probes are relativized for case, rather than category features.

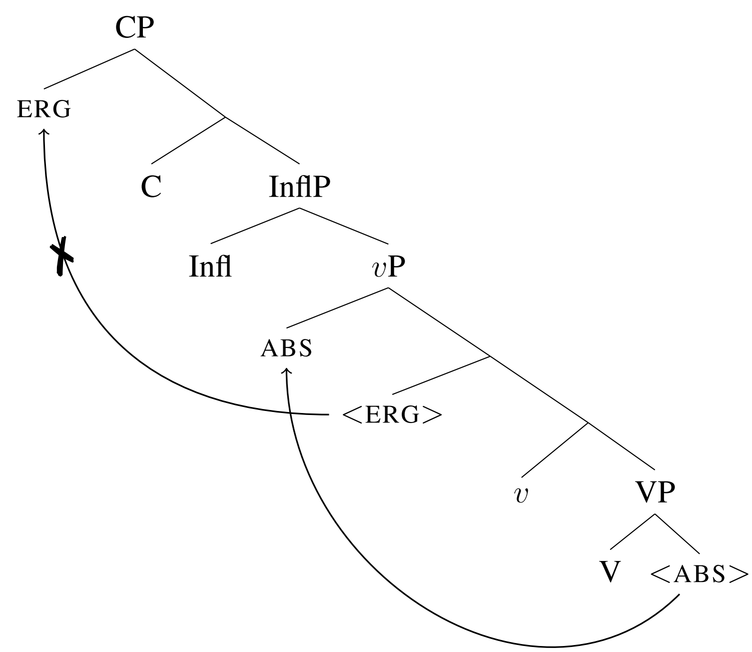
(9) a. * Which sonata$_j$ is this violin$_i$ easy to play ___$_j$ on ___$_i$?

b. Which violin$_j$ is this sonata$_i$ easy to play ___$_i$ on ___$_j$?

(Steedman 1985:35 *via* TC2022:471)

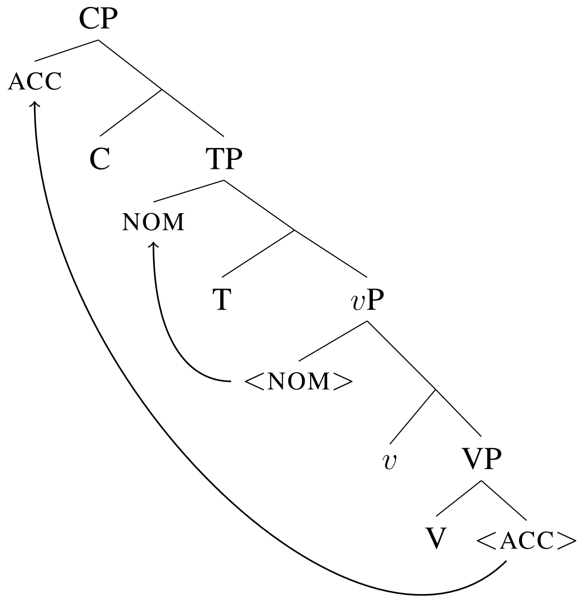
Under this approach, the ban on ergative extraction arises from a combination of (i) absolutive raising to a position above the ergative and (ii) the Constraint on Crossing Dependencies. For example, the illicit extraction of an ergative agent in 3c arises due to the Ā-movement of the agent crossing the A-movement path of the raised absolutive (10). In contrast, nominative-accusative languages allow for the extraction of the accusative object over the derived subject position because this extraction would result in nested dependencies with the A-movement of the subject (11).[9]

(10) Ergative extraction violates the Constraint on Crossing Dependencies:



[9]Note that this is only true if we discard the standard assumption that Ā-movement of the internal argument must proceed successive-cyclically through the vP edge, stopping in a position above the external argument (Chomsky 2001 *et seq.*) or allow the computation to disregard intermediate positions in a chain.

(11) Accusative extraction results in nested dependencies:



It has been noted since the advent of research on crossing dependencies that languages differ in their degree of tolerance towards such constructions. For example, Maling and Zaenen (1982) observe that while Swedish disallows structures with crossing dependencies, analogous sentences are grammatical in Norwegian and Icelandic (12). TC2022 mention a number of other counterexamples to the Constraint on Crossing Dependencies, including clause-final verb clusters in Dutch (Bach et al. 1986) and multiple *wh*-movement constructions in Bulgarian (Rudin 1988; Richards 1997; Bošković 2002) and Basque (Ortiz de Urbina 1989; Jeong 2007).

(12) Licit crossing dependency in Norwegian:

Denne gaven$_i$ her vil du ikke gjette hvem$_j$ jeg fikk __$_i$ fra __$_j$.
this gift here will you not guess who I got from

'This gift, you cannot guess who I got __ from __.' (Norwegian; Maling and Zaenen 1982:236 *via* Dalrymple and King 2013:140)

The Constraint on Crossing Dependencies thus cannot be a universal structural constraint: there are languages for which it is not operative. As a result, the account in TC2022, similarly to CBL2021, predicts the possibility of a language that displays high absolutive syntax without a ban on ergative extraction—this would simply be a language like Norwegian or Bulgarian, where crossing dependencies are tolerated, with the addition of an EPP feature which triggers movement of the internal argument to a position above the external argument. This analysis then similarly fails to derive the implicational relationship between syntactic ergativity and ergative extraction: a language may have high absolutive syntax, and correspondingly display syntactic ergativity effects, without barring the extraction of the ergative.

To conclude this section, analyses which connect the ban on ergative extraction with high absolutive syntax require an additional ingredient to derive the ban: in an intervention-based account, the probe triggering Ā-movement must be relativized so that the high absolutive DP intervenes for ergative extraction; an account which appeals to the Constraint on Crossing Dependencies must invoke a constraint which is not universally operative, meaning that, once again, the ban on ergative displacement is derived through the combination of high absolutive syntax and another, independently variable, parameter. This predicts that high absolutive syntax should be attested in the absence of a ban on ergative extraction, in contradiction with the implicational hierarchy assumed in most literature on syntactic ergativity. The following section demonstrates that this is indeed a desirable prediction: West Circassian is a high absolutive language which displays a number of syntactic ergativity effects, but allows for ergative displacement.

3. WEST CIRCASSIAN: SYNTACTIC ERGATIVITY WITHOUT A BAN ON ERGATIVE DISPLACEMENT. This section demonstrates that a language may display high absolutive syntax without a ban on ergative displacement, based on data from West Circassian. In West Circassian, a number of syntactic rules treat absolutive arguments differently from ergatives (and applied arguments): (i) constraints on reciprocal binding; (ii) conditions on parasitic gap licensing; and (iii) patterns of possessor subextraction (Ershova 2019, 2021, 2023b, 2024; see also Lander 2009b, 2012b; Letuchiy 2010). Within the Minimalist, tree-geometric framework assumed here, the most parsimonious solution to this disparate set of syntactic ergativity effects is to posit a high absolutive syntax wherein absolutive arguments (both subjects of intransitives and themes of transitive verbs) move to a dedicated position which c-commands the position of the ergative agent. However, this movement does not have an effect on ergative extraction: ergatives may be displaced similarly to other arguments.

3.1. BACKGROUND. West Circassian (also known as Adyghe) is a Northwest Caucasian language primarily spoken in the Republic of Adygea in Russia and diaspora communities in Turkey and the Middle East.[10] West Circassian is polysynthetic, with multiple arguments indexed on the

[10] The discussion of West Circassian relies on data from published sources, the Adyghe Language Corpus (AC) designed by Timofey Arkhangelskiy, Irina Bagirokova, Yury Lander and Anna Lander (`http://adyghe.web-corpora.net/`), and the author's fieldwork data, collected between 2017-2019 in the Shovgenovsky district of the Republic of Adygea in Russia. Unless otherwise indicated, all examples are in the Temirgoy dialect or the literary standard, which is based on the Temirgoy dialect. Segmentation and glossing of examples from cited work

predicate, free word order, and pronominal arguments frequently left unexpressed outside of the verbal indexing (see e.g. Arkadiev et al. 2009; Lander and Testelets 2017; Ershova 2019; Arkadiev and Lander 2020; Arkadiev 2023). For example, the predicate in 13 indexes four participants, and the pronouns referring to the first and second person participants are not expressed independently of the cross-reference morphology.[11]

(13) w-jə-čəle.ʁʷə-me selam
2SG.PR-POSS-fellow.villager-PL.OBL greeting
Ø- qə- p-fə- s- a- ʁe- hə -ž'ə -ʁ
3ABS- DIR- 2SG.IO-BEN- 1SG.IO+DAT- 3SG.ERG- CAUS- carry -RE -PST
'Your fellow villagers had me bring you greetings.' (AC)

West Circassian displays ergative alignment in both verbal indexing and case marking. In the domain of verbal indexing, the theme of a transitive verb and the sole argument of an intransitive verb are both indexed by the leftmost (absolutive) cross-reference prefix (e.g. the first person in 14a-14b), prefixes referring to applied arguments (of which there may be several) appear to the right of the absolutive prefix (e.g. the second and first person participants in 13), and the prefix indexing the external argument of a transitive verb—the third person plural causer in 13—appears closest to the verbal root, as shown schematically in 15.[12]

(14) a. **sə-** q- jə- š'a -ʁ
1SG.ABS- DIR- 3SG.ERG- bring -PST
'S/he brought me'

may be altered for internal consistency.

[11] Some of the cross-reference markers do not have overt exponence, such as the absolutive third person prefix in 13, as well as third person singular prefixes indexing alienable possessors (16) and applied arguments (17). These form a predictable part of the cross-reference paradigm and can be positionally identified, and I uniformly segment them as null morphemes and gloss them correspondingly. Belyaev et al. 2021 propose that third person absolutive arguments do not trigger prefixal cross-reference marking at all. However, even under such an account third person absolutive arguments still affect verbal indexing by triggering suffixal plural marking (i).

(i) s-laqʷe-xe-r Ø-z-ʁe-wəc̣ənə-ʁe**-x**
1SG.PR-foot-PL-ABS 3ABS-1SG.ERG-CAUS-wet-PST**-PL**
'I got my feet wet.'

[12] The morphological order of the cross-reference markers only partially correlates with the structural or thematic hierarchy of arguments: the leftmost position of the absolutive prefix straightforwardly correlates with the absolutive argument being the highest in the clause, but the relative order of applicative and ergative prefixes is inverse to the relative positions of the arguments and must be derived through postsyntactic metathesis (see Ershova 2019 for a technical implementation). The ordering is also not based on thematic roles: for a ditransitive predicate, the order of prefixes from right to left corresponds to the thematic hierarchy, but this is not maintained for absolutive-oblique two-place predicates or applicativized unergatives, where the more agentive argument is indexed by the leftmost absolutive prefix.

b. **sə-** qe- ḳʷa **-ʁ**
1SG.ABS- DIR- go -PST
'I went' (Rogava and Keraševa 1966:137-138 *via* Ershova 2023b:202-203)

(15) Order of cross-reference prefixes: ABS- IO+APPL- ERG-

In the domain of case marking, the absolutive suffix *-r* appears on nominals referring to the sole argument of an intransitive verb (16) and the theme of a transitive verb (17), whereas the oblique suffix *-m* appears on nominals referring to the ergative agent and applied arguments: for example, it appears on both the agent and the locative applied argument in 17. The oblique case marker is also used to mark possessors (18) and complements of postpositions (19).

(16) mə pŝaŝe**-r** Ø-jane paje Ø-qa-ŝʷe
this girl**-ABS** 3SG.PR-mother for 3ABS-DIR-dance
'This girl is dancing for her mother.'

(17) pŝaŝe**-m** məẑʷe**-r** psə**-m** Ø-Ø-x-jə-ʒa-ʁ
girl**-OBL** stone-ABS water**-OBL** 3ABS-3SG.IO-LOC-throw-PST
'The girl threw the stone into the water.'

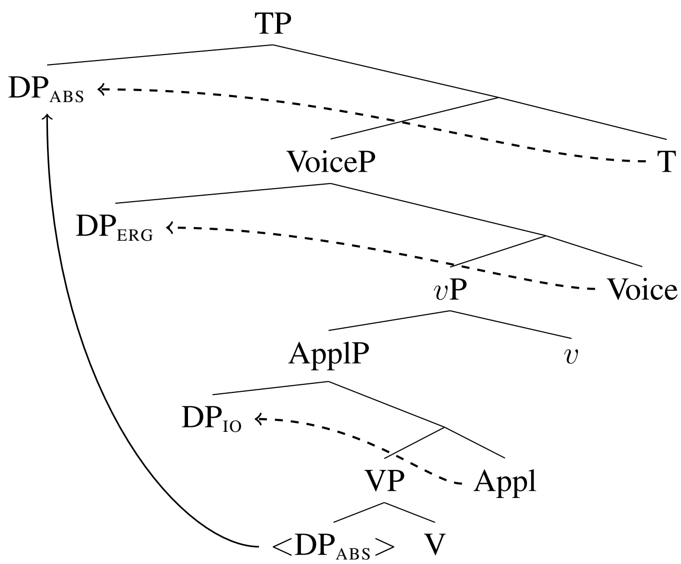
(18) č̣'ale**-m** ə-š-xe-m
boy**-OBL** 3SG.PR-brother-PL-OBL
'the boy's brothers'

(19) dəŝe-pceẑəje**-m** paje
gold-fish**-OBL** for
'for/about the golden fish'

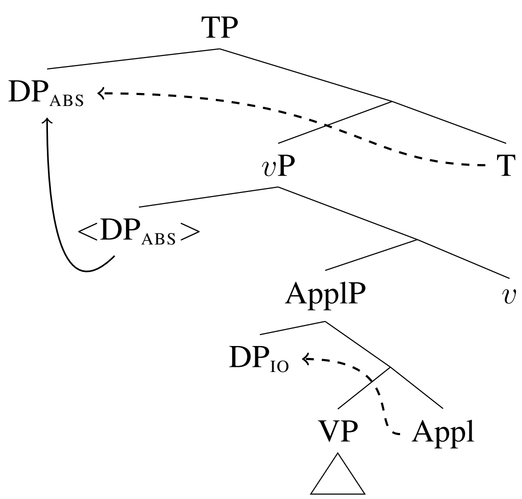
Personal pronouns, proper nouns, possessed nouns in the singular, and indefinite noun phrases are usually unmarked for case, as illustrated with the indefinite absolutive theme in 13 and the possessed nominal in 16 (Arkadiev et al. 2009:51-52, Arkadiev and Testelets 2019).

Ershova (2019, 2021, 2023b, 2024) argues that West Circassian is a high absolutive language: the absolutive argument in both transitive and intransitive clauses moves to a position c-commanding the ergative agent and all other verbal arguments. Following the cited works, I assume that this movement is driven by a case licensing requirement: while the ergative and applied arguments are licensed in situ by inherent case, the absolutive argument is assigned case by T^0 and correspondingly moves to Spec,TP. To account for the absence of ergative case and indexing with unergative external arguments (as well as a productive class of two-place absolutive-oblique predicates), I follow Massam 2009; Tollan 2018; Tollan and Oxford 2018; Tollan and Massam 2022; McGinnis 2022; Ershova 2023a, 2025; Burukina and Polinsky 2025 in positing two distinct heads for ergative and absolutive external arguments: ergative arguments are introduced and assigned ergative case by Voice^0, whereas absolutive external arguments are introduced by the lower v^0 and are assigned absolutive case by T^0. Finally, applied arguments are introduced and assigned inherent case by $Appl^0$. This is illustrated for a ditransitive predicate in 20 and an unergative verb with an applied argument in 21.

(20) High absolutive syntax with ditransitive predicate



(21) High absolutive syntax with applicativized unergative



Regardless of the specific theoretical implementation, the main generalization regarding West Circassian clause structure, which I will be defending in the following subsection, is that the absolutive argument displays several subject-like properties, i.e. properties which are associated with being the highest, or most structurally privileged, nominal in the clause.

The following subsection discusses the evidence for high absolutive syntax, which comes from several disparate syntactic phenomena: patterns of anaphor binding, conditions on parasitic gap licensing, and constraints on possessor subextraction. Since this part of the paper is largely a review of previously published work, I focus primarily on the evidence from reciprocal binding and only briefly mention the other two diagnostics with references. The last part of this section demonstrates that, despite the high position of the absolutive argument, the ergative argument is accessible for relativization, thus confirming the disassociation of syntactic ergativity from constraints on ergative extraction.

3.2. SYNTACTIC ERGATIVITY IN WEST CIRCASSIAN. This subsection outlines the evidence for high absolutive syntax in West Circassian, with a primary focus on patterns of reciprocal binding.

Anaphor binding in West Circassian is discussed in detail in Ershova 2023b (see also Letuchiy 2010). This paper only discusses reciprocal binding, which provides evidence for a high absolutive syntax; see Ershova 2023b for discussion of reflexive binding and why it fails to follow a syntactically ergative pattern.

Reciprocal binding is primarily expressed in the morphology with a specialized reciprocal morpheme *ze(re)-*. This morpheme replaces agreement with one of the coindexed participants without affecting the valency of the corresponding predicate, surfacing as *ze-* in the applied argument position (22) and *zere-* in the position indexing the ergative argument (23) or transitive causee (24) (the final vowel /e/ is dropped if immediately followed by a vowel or glide). The null third person prefix in 23 is indexing the absolutive antecedent ('they')—somewhat foreshadowing the main argument of this subsection—whereas the unpronounced third person prefix in the applicative position is indexing the location which is recoverable from the larger context ('the weddings'). In 24 the personal prefix indexing the transitive causee appears in the position associated with applied arguments and is usually accompanied by the dative applicative marker *(j)e-* (Letuchiy 2009), which is unpronounced in this example due to regular morphophonological rules. It is clear that the reciprocal prefix in 24 occupies the applicative position due to its appearance to the left of the third person plural ergative prefix indexing the antecedent.

(22)

tə-	qə-	**ze-**	d-	e-	ŝʷe
1PL.ABS-	DIR-	**RECP.IO-**	COM-	DYN-	dance

'We are dancing with each other.' (Ershova 2023b:206)

(23)

Ø-	Ø-	š'ə-	**zere-**	ʁe-	čefə	-x
3ABS-	3SG.IO-	LOC-	**RECP.ERG-**	CAUS-	rejoice	-PL

'They enjoyed themselves with each other (lit. made each other rejoice) [at the weddings].' (*ibid.*:207)

(24) senehat-xe-r Ø- **zer-** a- ʁe- ʁʷetə -ʁe -x
profession-PL-ABS 3ABS- **RECP.IO-** 3PL.ERG- CAUS- obtain -PST -PL
'They let/helped each other obtain professions.' (*ibid.*:204)

The correlation between the position of the reciprocal morpheme and the grammatical role of the bound argument suggests that this morpheme tracks agreement with a covert reciprocal anaphor and is not the spellout of a detransitivizing operator. Further support for this view comes from the absence of any effect on the case frame of the predicate it combines with: for example, the noun phrase referring to the ergative antecedent of the reciprocal applied object in 25 is marked with oblique case and triggers ergative indexing on the predicate, exactly as it would have in the absence of the reciprocal morphology.

(25) (...) a-xe-**me** zanč̣'-ew zewəže
that-PL-**PL.OBL** direct-ADV all
Ø- **ze-** r- a- ʔʷete -ž'ə -š'tə -ʁe
3ABS- **RECP.IO-** DAT- 3PL.ERG- tell -RE -IPF -PST
'They certainly told the whole truth to each other.' (Rogava and Keraševa 1966:274 *via* Ershova 2023b:209)

Reciprocal co-indexation is sensitive to thematic prominence, as expected if the reciprocal pronoun is an anaphor subject to Condition A of Binding Theory (Chomsky 1981 *et seq.*). Thus, if an ergative agent is co-indexed with a benefactive applied object, the reciprocal morpheme may appear in the position indexing the applied object (26a), but may not appear in the position referring to the ergative agent (26b).

(26) Ergative agent binds applied argument:

a. **IO-** **ERG-**
te wəne-xe-r Ø- **ze-** fe- t- ṣ̂ə -ž'ə -ʁ
we house-PL-ABS 3ABS- **RECP.IO-** BEN- 1PL.ERG- do -RE -PST

b. * te wəne-xe-r Ø- t- fe- **ze(re)-** ṣ̂ə -ž'ə -ʁ
we house-PL-ABS 3ABS- 1PL.IO- BEN- **RECP.ERG-** do -RE -PST
'We built houses for each other.' (Rainer Feer, p.c.; based on Ershova 2023b:213)

Similarly, if the absolutive agent of an unergative verb is co-indexed with an applied object, the reciprocal morpheme may only appear in the applied object position (27a), and may not replace the absolutive cross-reference marker (27b).

(27) Absolutive agent binds applied argument:

a.

ABS-		**IO-**			
tə-	qə-	**ze-**	d-	e-	ŝʷe
1PL.ABS-	DIR-	**RECP.IO-**	COM-	DYN-	dance

‘We are dancing with each other.’

b.

* **ze(re)**-	qə-	d-	d-	e-	ŝʷe
RECP.ABS-	DIR-	1PL.IO-	COM-	DYN-	dance

Intended: ‘We are dancing with each other.’ (*ibid.*:213)

Thus, an applied object may be bound by an absolutive or ergative case-marked agent, as expected, given the standard assumption that agents are structurally higher than applied arguments. The position of the reciprocal morpheme can thus be used to diagnose the relative structural positions of arguments: of the two co-indexed arguments, the one which is structurally lower will trigger reciprocal agreement. If this logic is applied to configurations which involve a co-indexed theme, it is evident that West Circassian behaves in a syntactically ergative fashion: the absolutive theme, despite being thematically outranked by both the ergative agent and the applied argument, may bind an ergative or applied argument, whereas the inverse binding configuration is ungrammatical. This is shown for an ergative-absolutive predicate in 28 and for a di-transitive predicate in 29.

(28) Absolutive theme binds ergative agent:

a.

Theme(ABS)-	**Agent(ERG)-**		
te-	**zere-**	λeʁʷə	-ʁ
1PL.ABS-	**RECP.ERG-**	see	-PST

b.

* **ze(re)**-	t-	λeʁʷə	-ʁ
RECP.ABS-	1PL.ERG-	see	-PST

‘We saw each other’ (*ibid.*:214)

(29) Absolutive theme binds applied argument:

a.

Theme(ABS)-	**IO-**		**Agent(ERG)-**		
tə-	**ze-**	f-	jə-	š’a	-ʁ
1PL.ABS-	**RECP.IO-**	BEN-	3SG.ERG-	bring	-PST

b.

* **ze-**	t-	f-	jə-	š’a	-ʁ
RECP.ABS-	1PL.IO-	BEN-	3SG.ERG-	bring	-PST

‘S/he brought us together (lit. to each other).’ (*ibid.*:215)

A reviewer asks if the patterns in 28-29 might be a consequence of the categorical non-existence of absolutive reciprocal morphology, perhaps akin to the non-existence of nominative anaphors in many languages (see e.g. Rizzi 1990; Woolford 1999), rather than bone fide binding of a thematically higher argument by the absolutive theme. Presumably, the example in 28a would then be the result of an operation akin to antipassivization: the external argument would be encoded as the absolutive antecedent and the reciprocal morphology would be indexing a demoted theme in an applied argument position.[13] There are two reasons why such an explanation is unlikely. Firstly, there is no categorical ban on anaphor agreement in the absolutive position: the absolutive theme may trigger reflexive agreement when bound by an ergative agent (30) or applied argument (31) (Ershova 2023b argues that reflexives are bound in the thematic domain prior to the raising of the absolutive to a higher position, resulting a syntactically accusative pattern).

(30) **zə-** t- λeʁʷə -ʁ
REFL.ABS- 1PL.ABS- see -PST
'We saw ourselves.' (Ershova 2023b:216)

(31) **zə-** s- jə- ʔe -ž' zepət
REFL.ABS- 1SG.IO- LOC- be -RE always
'I always have myself.' (lit. 'Myself is always at me.') (*ibid.*:223)

Secondly, the form in 28a does not display properties of an antipassive. Some ergative-absolutive predicates which have a root ending in /ə/ may be antipassivized by substituting this vowel for /e/ (Letuchiy 2010; Arkadiev and Letuchiy 2021): for example, the transitive verb *txən* 'write (something)' (32) has the intransitive variant *txen* 'write (generally)' (33; the root-final /e/ becomes /a/ due to regular morphophonological rules).

(32) txəλə-r Ø-ṭəs-jə Ø-ə-**txə**-ʁ
book-ABS 3ABS-sit.down-ADD 3ABS-3SG.ERG-write-PST
'S/he sat down at wrote the book.' (AC)

(33) adəɣe-ç̣'ele.je.ǯa.ḳʷe-xe-r Ø-**txa**-ʁe-x
Adyghe-student-PL-ABS 3ABS-**write(AP)**-PST-PL
'Adyghe students wrote.' (AC)

Indeed, *λeʁʷən* 'see' in 30 may be detransitivized in this manner, primarily when it is embedded under a synthetic causative (34). In contrast to the intransitive usage, the predicate in 30 ends in /ə/ rather than /e/, confirming that it has not been detransitivized.

[13] As potential support for this type of approach Lander and Letuchiy (2010:270) and Lander (2012a:133-134) have treated the marker *zere-* as a combination the reciprocal marker *ze-* which surfaces in the applied argument position and the applicative marker *re-* (see also Fong to appear). As discussed in Ershova 2023b:fn.18, the main issue with this approach is that *re-* is not an expected allomorph for any existing applicative marker in this morphophonological context. This approach is also not supported by the morphosyntax of antipassivization, as discussed below.

(34) je.ʁa.ṣ̂.jə djel-ew wə-z-ʁe-**λeʁʷa**-ʁ-ep
never stupid-ADV 2SG.ABS-1SG.ERG-CAUS-**see(AP)**-PST-NEG
'I have never made you look like a fool.'

Finally, while antipassivization is frequently accompanied by the omission of the theme argument (33), some predicates may retain the internal argument by indexing it with a dative applicative prefix: thus, while the verb of consumption *ŝʷən* 'drink' may be used with an ergative-absolutive case frame (35a), it is also used with the root-final vowel /e/ and an absolutive-dative case frame as *(je)ŝʷen* 'drink' (35b).

(35) a. mwe č̣'ale-m sena-bẑe-r Ø-ə-št-jə ... sane-r
that boy-OBL wine-horn-ABS 3ABS-3SG.ERG-take-ADD wine-ABS
Ø-Ø-r-jə-**ŝʷə-ʁ**
3ABS-3SG.IO-LOC-3SG.ERG-**drink**-PST
'That guy took the horn and ... drank the wine.' (Arkadiev and Letuchiy 2021:503)

b. kʷə-m Ø-qə-Ø-bʁʷeda-he-x-jə baχsəme-m
cart-OBL 3ABS-3SG.IO-LOC-enter-PL-ADD boza-OBL
Ø-**Ø-je-ŝʷa**-ʁe-x Ø-šxa-ʁe-x
3ABS-**3SG.IO-DAT-drink(AP)**-PST-PL 3ABS-eat(AP)-PST-PL
'They approached the cart and drank boza (fermented beverage) and ate.' (AC)

If the dative applied argument of an absolutive-dative predicate (e.g. *(je)pλən* 'look') triggers reciprocal agreement, it surfaces as *ze-*, rather than *zere-* (36). In this example the vowel /e/ in the reciprocal marker is dropped and the dative prefix *(j)e-* is unpronounced due to the following vocalic morpheme. This confirms the generalization that *ze-* is the morpheme associated with the reciprocal anaphor in applied argument position, whereas *zere-* expones agreement with a reciprocal pronoun in the position of an external argument: the ergative agent (23) or the transitive causee in a synthetic causative (24).

(36) tə-**z-**e-pλə-ž'ə
1PL.ABS-**RECP.IO-**DYN-look-DYN
'We are looking at each other.'

To summarize, the generalization for reciprocal binding in West Circassian is that the absolutive argument binds both applied and ergative arguments, even if they are higher than the absolutive argument in the thematic hierarchy. These binding patterns provide evidence for the promotion of the absolutive theme to a position above the ergative agent and applied argument, as shown in 20. Based on this diagnostic, West Circassian has a syntactically ergative clause structure, with the absolutive argument occupying a high position. This result is further confirmed by morphosyntactic constraints on relativization which are described in detail elsewhere: (i) for most speakers, possessor relativization is grammatical only from absolutive arguments (Lander 2012b; Ershova 2024), and (ii) relativization of an absolutive argument cannot license parasitic gaps in the structurally lower ergative and applied arguments (Ershova 2021).

According to the standard typology of ergative languages, the range of syntactic ergativity effects observed in West Circassian predicts syntactic ergativity in relation to ergative displacement. The following subsection demonstrates that this is not confirmed: ergative arguments may be relativized in the same fashion as absolutives.

3.3. ERGATIVE EXTRACTION. This subsection demonstrates that Ā-extraction of all types of arguments, including both absolutives and ergatives, displays properties that are associated with movement dependencies: it is island-sensitive, it licenses parasitic gaps, and it displays crossover effects. This confirms that West Circassian does not display a ban on ergative displacement, despite displaying a number of other syntactic ergativity effects.

All examples in this subsection involve relativization because it is the only type of Ā-movement observed in the language (Caponigro and Polinsky 2011). Focus fronting and wh-questions are formed with pseudo-cleft constructions which involve a relative clause; alternatively, wh-questions may be formed with a wh-word appearing in situ (Sumbatova 2009). The language displays free word order, suggesting that there are extensive possibilities for scrambling, but the rules and constraints underlying these operations have not been studied (Ershova 2022 suggests that at least some word order permutations are derived through A-scrambling)—to my knowledge, there appear to be no asymmetries between different arguments and their availability for scrambling.

Relative clauses in West Circassian involve the appearance of specialized relativizing morphology in place of the cross-reference marker referring to the relativized participant, which I gloss as WH for *wh*-agreement following Ershova 2021, 2024; see also Lander 2009a, 2012b; Caponigro and Polinsky 2011. For example, in order to relativize the dative applied object in 37a, the noun phrase referring to the relativized participant no longer appears in its clause-internal position and the corresponding cross-reference prefix (which is null in this case) is replaced with *ze-*[14] (37b). The head of the relative clause either appears at the left edge and is marked with the adverbial suffix *-ew*, as in 37b, or appears on the right edge with the case suffix associated with its position in the matrix clause (39b). Relative clauses may also be headless, as in the pseudo-cleft construction in 38b. The position or overtness of the nominal head does not affect the internal syntax of the relative clause.

[14]This morpheme also surfaces as *zə-* or *z-* in accordance with regular phonological rules.

(37) a. **mə č̣’ale-m(IO)** ə-š velosjəped
this boy-OBL 3SG.PR-brother bicycle
Ø- qə- **Ø-** r- jə- tə -ʁ
3ABS- DIR- **3SG.IO-** DAT- 3SG.ERG- give -PST
‘His brother gave a bicycle to this boy.’

b. marə [**č̣’al-ew$_i$** t_i(IO) ə-š velosjəped
here **boy-ADV** 3SG.PR-brother bicycle
Ø- qə- **ze-** r- jə- tə -ʁe] -r
3ABS- DIR- **WH.IO-** DAT- 3SG.ERG- give -PST -ABS
‘Here is the boy to whom his brother gave a bicycle.’ (Ershova 2021:9)

Ergative arguments are relativized in the same way: the third person singular prefix which appears in the finite clause in 38a is replaced with *zə-* in the relative clause in 38b. Since this is a wh-question based on a pseudo-cleft construction, the relative clause is headless, its relative clause status diagnosed by (i) the absolutive case marker on the predicate heading the relative clause, (ii) the specialized relative marker on the same predicate, and (iii) the appearance of the question particle on the wh-word rather than the verb—an indication that the former is functioning as a matrix predicate (Sumbatova 2009).

(38) a. **mə pŝaŝe-m(ERG)** č̣’ale-m məʔerəse-r Ø- Ø- r- **jə-** tə -ʁ
this girl-OBL boy-OBL apple-ABS 3ABS- 3SG.IO- DAT- **3SG.ERG-** give -PST
‘This girl gave the apple to the boy.’

b. xet-a [$_{RC}$ *t*(ERG) č̣’ale-m məʔerəse-r
who-Q boy-OBL apple-ABS
Ø- Ø- je- **zə-** tə -ʁe] -r
3ABS- 3SG.IO- DAT- **WH.ERG-** give -PST -ABS
‘Who gave the boy the apple? (lit. Who is the one who gave the boy the apple?’)

Absolutive arguments are similarly relativized, but they do not trigger overt relativizing morphology: relativization of the absolutive causee in 39a, which is indexed with a null third person absolutive prefix, does not result in observable change in the morphology: the relativizing prefix in this case is unpronounced, like third person cross-reference marking (39b).

(39) a. **aslan(ABS)** Ø-jane **Ø-** ə- ʁa- šxe -r -ep
Aslan 3SG.PR-mother **3ABS-** 3SG.ERG- CAUS- eat -DYN -NEG
‘His mother does not feed Aslan.’

b. [$_{\text{RC}}$ t_i(ABS) Ø-jane **Ø-** ə- mə- ʁa- šxe -re]
3SG.PR-mother **WH.ABS-** 3SG.ERG- NEG- CAUS- eat -DYN
haẑʷə.š'ər-xe-m sə-gʷ Ø-a-fe-wəzə
puppy-PL-OBL 1SG.PR-heart 3ABS-3PL.IO-BEN-ache
'My heart aches for the puppies whom their mother doesn't feed.' (Ershova 2021:26)

Lander (2009a,b, 2012b); Lander and Daniel (2019) propose that the absence of *zə-* with absolutive relativization is indicative of this being an altogether different ("unmarked") relativization strategy. On the surface, then, this appears to be an effect very similar to the contrast between a gap and a resumptive pronoun in Tongan (1). Indeed, Lander (2009b) lists this morphological contrast among evidence for the subjecthood of the absolutive argument and Polinsky (2016:151-154) draws this analogy with Tongan directly, suggesting that *zə-* is historically a resumptive pronoun.[15] I depart from this view and follow Caponigro and Polinsky 2011; Ershova 2021, 2024 in positing a null relativizing prefix for absolutive relativization that forms part of the same paradigm as the overt marker appearing in other cross-reference slots. The presence of this null morpheme or the syntactic mechanism underlying the appearance of the relativizing morphology is not crucial, although I will return to this question in §4.4. The important takeaway is that, despite a contrast in morphological exponence, ergative arguments are relativized in the same way as absolutive arguments and display properties typically associated with movement dependencies.

Firstly, relativization is island-sensitive (also noted in Caponigro and Polinsky 2011:86 and Lander 2012b:285-287). For example, relativization is ungrammatical out of factive complements marked with *zere-*. Clauses with the prefix *zere-* display properties of headless relatives and have been analyzed as involving relativization of an unpronounced factive operator (Gerasimov and Lander 2008; Caponigro and Polinsky 2011; Lander 2012b:296-309); correspondingly, the islandhood of these constituents may be attributed to their status as relative clauses (Ross 1967, *et seq.*).

Relativization from *zere*-complements is ungrammatical for all types of arguments. Thus, the absolutive external argument in 40a may not be relativized (40b).

(40) a. se Ø-s-e-ṣ̂e [$_{\text{CP}}$ **mə pŝeŝe.ẑəje-r** dax-ew
I 3ABS-1SG.ERG-know **this girl-ABS** beautiful-ADV
Ø-qə-zera-ŝʷe-re-r]
3ABS-DIR-WH.FACT-dance-DYN-ABS
'I know that this girl dances well.'

b. * xet-a [$_{\text{RC}}$ [$_{\text{CP}}$ t(ABS) dax-ew **Ø-**qə-zera-ŝʷe-re-r]
who-Q beautiful-ADV **WH.ABS-**DIR-WH.FACT-dance-DYN-ABS

[15] Lander and Daniel (2019) also pursue a resumption-based analysis of the relativizing prefix *zə-*.

Ø-p-ṣ̂ə-re-r]
3ABS-2SG.ERG-know-DYN-ABS
Intended: 'Who is the one that you know [__ dances well]?'

Similarly, an applied argument such as the dative indirect object in 41a may not be relativized from the factive complement (41b).

(41) a. [CP **mə č̣'ale-m** zə-par-jə Ø-zer-**Ø-**je-mə-wa-ʁe-r]
this boy-OBL one-nobody-ADD 3ABS-WH.FACT-**3SG.IO-**DAT-NEG-hit-PST-ABS
Ø-s-e-ṣ̂e
3ABS-1SG.ERG-DYN-know
'I know that no one hit this boy.'

b. * marə [RC č̣'al-ew [CP *t*(IO) zə-par-jə
here boy-ADV one-nobody-ADD
Ø-zere-**z-**e-mə-wa-ʁe-r] Ø-s-ṣ̂e-re-r]
3ABS-WH.FACT-**WH.IO-**DAT-NEG-hit-PST-ABS 3ABS-1SG.ERG-know-DYN-ABS
Intended: 'Here is the boy whom I know [nobody hit __].'

Relativization of the ergative argument is island-sensitive in the same way: thus, the ergative agent in 42a may not be relativized from the *zere*-complement (42b).

(42) a. [CP mə č̣'ale-m deʁʷ-ew wered Ø-qə-zer-**jə-**ʔʷe-re-r]
this boy-OBL good-ADV song 3ABS-DIR-WH.FACT-**3SG.ERG-**say-DYN-ABS
Ø-s-e-ṣ̂e
3ABS-1SG.ERG-DYN-know
'I know that this boy sings (lit. says songs) well.'

b. * mə č̣'ale-r arə [RC se Ø-s-ṣ̂e-re-r [CP *t*(ERG)
this boy-ABS PRED I 3ABS-1SG.ERG-know-DYN-ABS
deʁʷ-ew wered Ø-qə-zere-**zə-**ʔʷe-re-r]]
good-ADV song 3ABS-DIR-WH.FACT-**WH.ERG-**say-DYN-ABS
Intended: 'This boy is the one I know [__ sings well].'

Relativization also licenses parasitic gaps—a property that is typical of movement dependencies (Engdahl 1983; Nissenbaum 2000; Culicover 2001, a.o.). Parasitic gaps in West Circassian can be diagnosed by the presence of an additional relativizing morpheme in the cross-reference slot that refers to the gapped argument and display the range of properties typical of parasitic gaps cross-linguistically (Ershova 2021). For example, if the unpronounced possessor of the absolutive external argument (which triggers null third person possessor marking on the head noun) in 43a is interpreted as bound by the relativized applied argument, it may be replaced by a parasitic gap, which is diagnosed by the appearance of the relativizing morpheme in place of the third person singular possessor marker on the head noun (43b).

(43) a. marə [$_{RC}$ č̣’ele-ç̣əḳ^{w}-ew$_{i}$ [*pro*$_{i}$(PR) **Ø-**jane](ABS) t_{i}(IO)
here boy-small-ADV **3SG.PR-**mother
Ø- **zə-** fe- g^{w}əbž’ -zepətə -re] -r
3ABS- **WH.IO-** BEN- be.angry -always -DYN -ABS
‘Here is the boy whom his mother is always angry at.’

b. marə [$_{RC}$ č̣’ele-ç̣əḳ^{w}-ew$_{i}$ [__$_{PG}$ **z-**jane](ABS) t_{i}(IO)
here boy-small-ADV **WH.PR-**mother
Ø- **zə-** fe- g^{w}əbž’ -zepətə -re] -r
3ABS- **WH.IO-** BEN- be.angry -always -DYN -ABS
lit. ‘Here is the boy whom [the mother of __] is always angry at __.’ (adapted from Ershova 2021:28)

43b is an example of a relativized applied argument licensing a parasitic gap. A relativized ergative argument is also able to license parasitic gaps: thus, the (unpronounced) pronoun which refers to the possessor of the absolutive theme and is indexed by null third person possessor indexing in 44 may be replaced by a parasitic gap—diagnosed once again by the appearance of the relativizing morpheme on the possessed noun. Note that this example also provides evidence for high absolutive syntax: one of the properties of parasitic gaps cross-linguistically is that they cannot be licensed by a c-commanding licensing gap (the so-called anti-c-command condition; Engdahl 1983), meaning that the ergative argument does not c-command the absolutive theme in 44.[16]

(44) marə [$_{RC}$ četəw-ew$_{i}$ [$_{DP}$ *pro*$_{i}$ / **__$_{PG}$**(PR) Ø / **z-**jə-šxən](ABS) t_{i}(ERG)
here cat-ADV 3SG/**WH.PR**-POSS-food
Ø- **zə-** mə- šxə -re] -r
3ABS- **WH.ERG-** NEG- eat -DYN -ABS
‘Here is the cat that doesn’t eat its food.’
or literally: ‘Here is the cat that __ doesn’t eat [the food of __].’(Ershova 2021:28)

Finally, relativization displays both Strong and Weak Crossover effects (Postal 1971 *et seq.*). A Strong Crossover configuration involves displacement of a relative or *wh*-operator over a co-

[16] For West Circassian relative clauses, the anti-c-command condition correctly predicts that a relativized absolutive argument cannot license parasitic gaps in ergative or applied arguments. A reviewer asks whether it also predicts that an ergative argument would not be able to license a parasitic gap inside an applied argument by virtue of c-commanding it. Ershova (2021) demonstrates that this prediction is not borne out, indicating that, in addition to absolutive raising, the applied argument may undergo local A-scrambling to a position above the ergative external argument; see the discussion in Ershova 2021 for details.

indexed pronominal (45), whereas Weak Crossover involves operator displacement over a constituent containing a co-indexed pronoun (46).

(45) * Who$_i$ does Mary think he$_i$ hurt __$_i$? (Postal 1971:74)

(46) * The pudding$_i$ which [the man who ordered it$_i$] said __$_i$ would be tasty was a horror show. (Ross 1967:131 *via* Postal 1971:87)

West Circassian relativization is sensitive to crossover, as expected of a displacement dependency. Thus, the applied argument of the complement clause of *jə-ç̣̌'ase* 'favorite' may not be relativized over the co-indexed applied argument in the matrix clause (47); instead, the applied argument itself must be relativized, with the option of a parasitic gap in the embedded clause (48).[17]

(47) * xet-a [$_{RC}$ ***pro*$_i$(IO)** Ø-jə-mə-ç̣̌'ase-r [$_{CP}$ ṣ̂ʷəhaftən-xe-r t_i(IO)
who-Q 3SG.IO-POSS-NEG-favorite-ABS gift-PL-ABS
Ø-qə-**ze-**r-a-tə-n-ew]]
3ABS-DIR-**WH.IO-**DAT-3PL.ERG-give-MOD-ADV
lit. 'Who$_i$ is it that they$_i$ dislike for them to give __$_i$ presents.'

(48) xet-a [$_{RC}$ ***t*$_i$(IO)** **z-**jə-mə-ç̣̌'ase-r [$_{CP}$ ṣ̂ʷəhaftən-xe-r *pro*$_i$ / __$_i$(IO)
who-Q **WH.IO-**POSS-NEG-favorite-ABS gift-PL-ABS
Ø-qə-{Ø-,ze-}r-a-tə-n-ew]]
3ABS-DIR-{3SG.IO-,WH.IO-}DAT-3PL.ERG-give-MOD-ADV
lit. 'Who is it that __$_i$ dislikes for them to give them$_i$ / __$_i$ presents.'

Ergative arguments display a similar effect: for example, the ergative agent of the embedded complement clause of *wəxən* 'finish' may not be relativized over the co-indexed ergative agent in the matrix clause (49). To express the relevant meaning, the matrix participant must be relativized, with the option of a parasitic gap in place of the ergative participant in the embedded clause (50).

(49) * marə [$_{RC}$ ŝʷəz-ew$_i$ ***pro*$_i$(ERG)** [$_{CP}$ Ø-jə-sabjəj-xe-r t_i(ERG)
here woman-ADV 3SG.PR-POSS-child-PL-ABS
Ø-**zə-**fepe-n-ew] Ø-ə-wəxə-ʁe-r]]
3ABS-**WH.ERG-**dress-MOD-ADV 3ABS-3SG.ERG-finish-ABS
lit. 'Here is the woman who she$_i$ finished [__$_i$ dressing her children].

[17] Parasitic gaps which are embedded in complement CPs in West Circassian systematically violate the anti-c-command condition; Ershova (2021:34) suggests that this may have to do with a general lack of Condition C effects in cross-clausal contexts. See also Testelets 2009 on Condition C violations in West Circassian and Contreras 1987; Horvath 1992, among others, on cross-clausal violations of the anti-c-command condition.

(50) marə [$_{RC}$ ŝ^{w}əz-ew$_i$ ***t*$_i$(ERG)** [$_{CP}$ Ø-jə-sabjəj-xe-r *pro*$_i$ / __$_i$(ERG)
here woman-ADV 3SG.PR-POSS-child-PL-ABS
Ø-{ə-,zə-}fepe-n-ew] **Ø-zə-**wəxə-ʁe-r]]
3ABS-{3SG.ERG-,WH.ERG-}dress-MOD-ADV 3ABS-**WH.ERG-**finish-PST-ABS
lit. 'Here is the woman who __$_i$ finished her$_i$ / __$_i$ dressing her children.'

West Circassian relativization also displays weak crossover effects: a relativized participant may not cross over a constituent containing a co-indexed pronoun (see also Ershova 2021:32-33). Thus, the absolutive external argument of the embedded complement clause of *fejen* 'want' may not be relativized over a co-indexed pronoun in the absolutive argument of the matrix predicate—a parasitic gap must be used instead (51).

(51) marə [$_{RC}$ pŝeŝe.ẑəj-ew$_i$ [__$_{PG}$ / **pro*$_i$ **z-/*Ø-**jane
here girl-ADV **WH.PR-/*3SG.PR-**mother
Ø-Ø-fa.je-r [$_{CP}$ *t*$_i$(ABS) kwencertə-m
3ABS-3SG.IO-want-ABS concert-OBL
Ø-qə-Ø-š'ə-ŝ^{w}e-n-ew]]
WH.ABS-DIR-3SG.IO-LOC-dance-MOD-ADV
'Here is the girl who$_i$ [the mother of __$_{PG}$ / *her$_i$] wants [__$_i$ to dance at the concert].'

The same effect is observed with relativization of an ergative argument: the ergative agent in 52 may not be relativized over the co-indexed pronoun in the matrix absolutive DP; instead, a parasitic gap must appear in place of the co-indexed possessor.

(52) mə pŝaŝe-r arə [$_{RC}$ [__$_{PG}$ / **pro*$_i$ **z-/*Ø-**jane]
this girl-ABS PRED **WH.PR-/*3SG.PR-**mother
Ø-Ø-fa.je-r [$_{CP}$ *t*$_i$(ERG) kwencertə-m wered
3ABS-3SG.IO-want-ABS concert-OBL song
Ø-qə-Ø-š'ə-**zə-**ʔ^{w}e-n-ew]]
3ABS-DIR-3SG.IO-LOC-**WH.ERG-**say-MOD-ADV
'This girl is the one who$_i$ [the mother of __$_{PG}$ / *her$_i$] wants [__$_i$ to sing (lit. say songs) at the concert].'

To conclude this subsection, relativization in West Circassian displays properties typically associated with movement dependencies: it is island-sensitive, it licenses parasitic gaps, and it triggers crossover effects. Ergative arguments are relativized in the same fashion as other types of participants, including the absolutive argument, thus confirming that West Circassian does not display a ban on ergative displacement.

3.4. SUMMARY: SYNTACTIC ERGATIVITY IN WEST CIRCASSIAN. One of the main claims of this paper is that a language with a syntactically ergative clause structure wherein the absolutive argument occupies a privileged position in the clause need not display a constraint on ergative displacement, counter to existing typologies of syntactically ergative languages. To support this claim, this section has presented evidence that West Circassian is a language with a broad range of syntactic ergativity effects which are manifested in conditions on reciprocal binding, parasitic gap licensing, and possessor relativization. However, ergative arguments may be displaced in West Circassian, similarly to absolutive and applied arguments, and the corresponding displacement dependencies display all the properties associated with movement dependencies cross-linguistically.

The movement-related tests presented in this section are particularly important because ergative relativization in West Circassian involves overt specialized morphology which does not appear in cases of absolutive relativization: while *wh*-agreement with a relativized absolutive argument is unpronounced, as can be seen in 51 and elsewhere, ergative relativization involves the use of an overt *wh*-agreement marker *zə-* (e.g. 52). Indeed, this contrast in exponence has occasionally been labeled as a syntactic ergativity effect, implying that this is the surface manifestation of a *syntactic rule* which discriminates between absolutive and ergative arguments (see e.g. Lander 2009b; Lander and Daniel 2019:1258; Polinsky 2016:151-154). However, this section has demonstrated that relativization of absolutive and ergative arguments has a uniform profile and passes the same set of diagnostics for syntactic displacement. This suggests that contrasts in morphological exponence cannot be used as a reliable diagnostic for the presence of a syntactic rule, such as the impossibility of ergative displacement. The following section further explores the connection between morphological exponence and syntactic constraints on movement through the example of another language which has been claimed to display a ban on ergative displacement—Samoan (Polinsky 2016; Hopperdietzel 2020; Hopperdietzel and Alexiadou 2024, 2025).

4. THE CONNECTION BETWEEN THE MORPHOLOGY OF ERGATIVE DISPLACEMENT AND SYNTACTIC ERGATIVITY. Traditionally, the main diagnostic for identifying the presence of syntactic ergativity in the domain of ergative displacement is the use of morphology which is not used in cases of absolutive extraction. The difference in morphology is taken to indicate a corresponding difference in the syntax: the additional morphology is utilized as a repair for an illicit derivation. For example, while an absolutive theme in Kalaallisut may be relativized with a gap (53a), relativization of an ergative agent in this manner is ungrammatical (53b). In order to relativize the transitive agent, the predicate must be marked with an antipassive suffix, which additionally correlates with the theme receiving an oblique (modalis) case and the verb displaying intransitive agreement with the agent (53c).

(53) a. miiqqat [$_{\text{RC}}$ Juuna-p _ paari-sai]
child.PL.ABS Juuna-ERG **(ABS)** look.after-PART.3SG.S/3PL.O
'the children that Juuna is looking after'

b. * angut [$_{\text{RC}}$ _ aallaat tigu-sima-saa]
man.ABS **(ERG)** gun.ABS take-PFV-PART.3SG.S/3SG.O
Intended: 'the man who took the gun'

c. angut [$_{\text{RC}}$ _ aalaam-mik tigu-si-sima-suq]
man.ABS **(ABS)** gun-MOD take-ANTIP-PFV-PART.3SG.S
'the man who took the gun' (Kalaallisut; Bittner 1994:55,58 *via* Yuan 2022:518)

This antipassive construction is grammatical in the absence of relativization, and the transitive subject in this construction is correspondingly marked with absolutive case (54). The different morphological form of the verb in cases of agent relativization thus clearly correlates with a change in argument alignment: the theme remains structurally low, and the relativized argument is absolutive, rather than ergative case-marked. This confirms that Kalaallisut does indeed display a syntactic ban on relativization of the ergative argument.

(54) suli **Juuna** atuakka-mik ataatsi-mik tigu-**si**-sima-nngi-laq
still **Juuna.ABS** book-MOD one-MOD get-**ANTIP**-PFV-NEG-3SG.S
'Juuna hasn't received (even) one book yet.' (Kalaallisut; Bittner 1994:35 *via* Yuan 2022:515)

However, for many of the languages which are traditionally classified as syntactically ergative, the correlation between the use of special morphology and the impossibility of ergative movement is less straightforward. For example, the agent focus construction which is used in cases of agent displacement in Mayan languages (5) is largely limited to these displacement contexts, which has led some researchers to treat this marker as a morphological reflex of ergative displacement rather than a repair strategy which re-configures the argument alignment of the clause (Stiebels 2006; Newman 2021, 2024).[18] Similarly, the previous section has demonstrated that ergative relativization in West Circassian employs a different morphological form to absolutive relativization, but this distinction in exponence is a surface phenomenon and does not correlate with a syntactic constraint on ergative extraction. This section further emphasizes the danger of equating the appearance of specialized morphology with the presence of a syntactic rule through the example of Samoan, a Polynesian language which has been claimed to display syntactic ergativity in the domain of ergative displacement (Polinsky 2016; Hopperdietzel 2020; Hopperdietzel and Alexiadou 2024, 2025).

[18] The notable exception to this is the use of agent focus in non-finite embedded transitives—the so-called "crazy antipassive" (Coon et al. 2014)—which casts doubt on the one-to-one correlation between ergative displacement and agent focus marking. Thanks to a reviewer for pointing this out.

The remainder of this section is organized as follows: §4.1 discusses ergativity in Samoan, with a focus on the suffix *-ina* which appears in clauses with ergative displacement. In §4.2 I demonstrate that ergative displacement, despite triggering additional morphology, displays typical movement properties, which suggests that *-ina* is not a reflex of syntactic ergativity. §4.3 presents an alternative analysis which derives the distribution of *-ina* from interactions between morphophonological constraints and the syntax-phonology interface. §4.4 summarizes and discusses the typological correlation between ergative displacement and the appearance of additional specialized morphology.

4.1. BACKGROUND. Samoan is a Polynesian language primarily spoken in Samoa, American Samoa, and diaspora communities in New Zealand, Australia, and the United States.[19] The language displays verb initial word order and ergative alignment in case marking and agreement (Chung 1978; Mosel 1985; Mosel and Hovdhaugen 1992; Collins 2017; Tollan 2018; Tollan and Massam 2022; Hopperdietzel 2020; Yu 2021, a.o.).[20] Thus, the agent of a transitive predicate is marked with the particle *e*, whereas the absolutive theme is not marked with overt segmental morphology (55).[21] In accordance with ergative alignment, subjects of intransitive predicates are unmarked, similarly to the theme of a transitive verb (56).

(55) Na fusi [**e** Talia]$_{\textbf{ERG}}$ [le tama'i maile]$_{\textbf{ABS}}$.
PST hug **ERG** Talia the small dog
'Talia hugged the puppy.'

(56) E aliali [ma'a]$_{\textbf{ABS}}$ pe-'a pē le tai.
PRES appear rock Q-FUT low the tide
'The rocks show when the tide goes down.'

Many two-place predicates select for an absolutive agent and an oblique case-marked theme; these are traditionally called semi-transitive or middle verbs and are generally associated with less agentive external argument roles, such as the experiencer in 57 (Chung 1978:46-65; Seiter 1978; Mosel 1985:104-108; Mosel and Hovdhaugen 1992:723; Tollan 2018).

(57) E alofa [le fafine]$_{\textbf{ABS}}$ [**i** l-a-na tama teine]$_{\textbf{OBL}}$.
PRES love the woman **OBL** the-GEN-3SG child girl

[19]The discussion of Samoan relies on data from published sources as well as data acquired through elicitations conducted in 2020-2023 with one speaker from Apia, Samoa.

[20]A small number of predicates agree with the absolutive argument in number; given the rather limited nature of the pattern and its irrelevance to the main claim of the paper, I do not discuss it further.

[21]Yu (2021) argues that absolutive case in Samoan is marked by a high edge tone. Since absolutive arguments may also be distinguished from other participants by the absence of an overt case particle, I do not include the tonal marking in this paper, in accordance with Samoan orthography.

‘The woman loves her daughter.’

Tollan (2018); Tollan and Massam (2022) analyze the oblique case on themes of semi-transitive verbs as accusative; since it is homophonous with oblique case on goals of ditransitives (58) as well as genuine adjuncts (59), I label the corresponding particle as OBLIQUE throughout.[22] I remain agnostic in regards to the sources of case assignment in the language, since the choice bears no significance for this paper.

(58) Na ave e Talia [**i** l-a-na tama teine] le tusi.
PST take ERG Talia **OBL** the-GEN-3SG child girl the book
‘Talia gave her daughter the book.’

(59) Na ou sau [**i** le vaiaso ua te’a].
PST 1SG arrive **OBL** the week PRV leave
‘I arrived last week.’

I follow Tollan 2018; Tollan and Massam 2022 in positing two positions for external arguments, analogously to the assumptions laid out for West Circassian in §3.1: ergative agents are introduced by Voice^0 and absolutive external arguments of semi-transitive and unergative verbs are introduced by a lower head v^0. The use of additional structure with ergative case-assigning verbs which is not used in the absence of ergative agents (Voice^0) will play a crucial role in the discussion of the morphosyntax of ergative displacement below.

Ergative agents and absolutive arguments of intransitive and semi-transitive predicates may be expressed as a preverbal clitic, which usually appears between the clause-initial TAM particle and the verb, as shown for the absolutive argument in 59 and the ergative argument in 60. Note that 60 involves the suffix *-ina* which has been previously analyzed as a repair for illicit ergative displacement; the contexts where this suffix appears will be discussed in detail below.

(60) Na **e** aumai-a l-a-’u tusi.
PST **2SG** bring-INA the-GEN-1SG book
‘You brought my book.’

The absolutive and ergative external arguments share subjecthood properties, such as accessibility for raising, control, and promotion to preverbal position (59-60) (Chung 1978; Cook 1991:95-210).[23] Furthermore, Condition C effects indicate that the ergative external argument

[22] Chung (1978) distinguishes between *i* ‘at’ and *’i* ‘to’. The two particles are homophonous and speakers do not reliably differentiate between them. I follow Mosel and Hovdhaugen 1992 in transcribing all instances of the oblique particle as *i*.

[23] However see Mosel 1987, 1991 for the view that none of the core arguments can be reliably classified as subject in Samoan.

is introduced higher than the absolutive theme both in the default VSO and the derived VOS word orders: co-indexation between a referential expression inside the ergative DP and a pronoun in the position of the absolutive theme does not result in a Condition C violation regardless of linear order (61).

(61) a. E tausi [e le tinā o Natia$_i$] ia$_{i/j}$.
PRES care ERG the mother GEN Natia s/he
'Natia$_i$'s mother is taking care of her$_{i/j}$.' VSO: no Condition C violation

b. E tausi ia$_{i/j}$ [e le tinā o Natia$_i$].
PRES care s/he ERG the mother GEN Natia
'Natia$_i$'s mother is taking care of her$_{i/j}$.' VOS: no Condition C violation

In contrast, a pronoun in the position of the ergative argument cannot bind a referential expression inside the DP referring to the absolutive theme—in accordance with Condition C this suggests that the ergative argument is structurally higher than the absolutive theme (62a). Taken together, this evidence suggests that Samoan does not display obligatory high absolutive syntax, unlike West Circassian. However, placing the DP referring to the absolutive theme to the left of the ergative case-marked pronoun (resulting in VOS word order) ameliorates the Condition C violation observed in (62a)—this suggests that in VOS word order, the absolutive DP may undergo A-movement to a position above the ergative DP (62b); see also discussion in Cook 1991.

(62) a. Na fafaga [e ia$_{i/*j}$] [le tama teine a le fafine$_j$].
PST feed ERG s/he the child girl GEN the woman
'S/he$_{i/*j}$ fed the woman$_j$'s daughter.'

b. Na fafaga [le tama teine a le fafine$_j$] [e ia$_{i/j}$].
PST feed the child girl GEN the woman ERG s/he
'S/he$_i$ fed the woman$_j$ daughter.'
Or: 'The woman$_j$ fed her$_j$ daughter.'

The interaction between absolutive raising and amelioration of Condition C effects is relevant for the alternative analysis of the morphology associated with ergative displacement that is proposed in §4.3.

Ergative arguments contrast with absolutive arguments in triggering the appearance of an additional morpheme *-ina* in displacement contexts; this pattern is shown in 63-65 with phrasal fronting with the focus particle *o* (glossed as ALT for alternative, following Hohaus and Howell 2015). When an ergative argument is fronted, the suffix *-ina* (which alternates freely with the allomorph *-a*) appears on the predicate (63). In contrast, the fronting of either an absolutive theme (64) or absolutive external argument (65) does not trigger any additional morphology.

(63) O [Natia]$_{ERG}$ na ave**-a** l-o-'u nofoa?
ALT Natia PST take**-INA** the-GEN-1SG chair
'Is it Natia who took my chair?'

(64) O [le nofoa]$_{ABS}$ na ave e Talia.
ALT the chair PST take ERG Talia
'It's the chair that Talia took.'

(65) O [a'u]$_{ABS}$ e alofa i l-a-'u fānau.
ALT I PRES love OBL the-GEN-1SG children
'It's me who loves my children.'

Hopperdietzel (2020); Hopperdietzel and Alexiadou (2025) analyse this morphological pattern as the manifestation of a ban on ergative displacement. Hopperdietzel (2020:156-162) suggests that *-ina* is the realization of a resumptive pronoun in the position of the ergative agent, akin to the resumptive clitic observed in cases of displacement in Tongan (1a), which has likewise been characterized as syntactically ergative in regards to ergative extraction (Otsuka 2006; Polinsky 2016, 2017, though see Otsuka 2017 for a reanalysis of Tongan resumption without reference to syntactic ergativity). The author also mentions that the same suffix surfaces when the ergative argument is expressed as a preverbal clitic (60) and suggests that the ergative agent cannot undergo displacement of any type, including cliticization, due to being a PP, following Polinsky's (2016) analysis of similar syntactic ergativity effects. In anticipation of the discussion below, the appearance of *-ina* with ergative preverbal clitics is already a challenge for this suffix being a repair for illicit ergative extraction, since clitic fronting does not fall into the usual class of displacement contexts which display this effect; I return to this issue in §4.3.

The association between *-ina* and ergative displacement is indeed robust: the same suffix is used in relative clauses with a relativized ergative argument, as well as *wh*-questions where the fronted *wh*-element corresponds to the ergative agent (Chung 1978:81-94; Mosel 1985:62-98; Mosel and Hovdhaugen 1992:741-763). However, the following subsection presents evidence that ergative displacement displays properties typical of movement dependencies despite the presence of *-ina*, which suggests the absence of a ban on ergative displacement. Furthermore, *-ina* contrasts with bona fide resumption, which may be used to ameliorate illicit movement dependencies. The treatment of *-ina* as a resumptive pronoun is further challenged by its appearance in configurations without ergative displacement, which are discussed in §4.3.

4.2. MOVEMENT PROPERTIES OF ERGATIVE DISPLACEMENT AND REPAIR BY RESUMPTION. This section presents evidence that Samoan does not display a ban on ergative displacement, suggesting that *-ina* is not a repair strategy for an illicit movement derivation. In particular, I argue that ergative displacement displays properties that are typical of movement dependencies. Furthermore, I contrast the use of *-ina* with true resumption which may be used to ameliorate instances of illicit ergative fronting.

Firstly, a fronted noun phrase which is interpreted as the ergative participant may not be separated from the predicate marked with *-ina* by an island boundary: focus fronting of the ergative agent from the reason clause in 66 is ungrammatical despite the presence of *-ina* on the embedded predicate (67).

(66) Na ave atu e Talia [ona sā **ou** ta'u-a iā te ia o l-o-u aso
PST take thither ERG Talia COMP PST **I** tell-INA OBL s/he PRED the-GEN-2SG day
fānau lenei.
born today
'Talia gave it [=the present] to you because I told her that it's your birthday today.'

(67) * O a'u$_i$ na ave atu e Talia le mealofa [ona sā t_i ta'u**-a** iā te ia
ALT I PST give thither ERG Talia the gift COMP PST give**-INA** OBL s/he
o l-o-u aso fānau lenei.
PRED the-GEN-2SG day born today
Intended: 'It's me, Talia gave the present to you because I told her that it's your birthday today.'

Secondly, ergative displacement displays crossover effects. Thus, 68 is grammatical under the interpretation where the possessor in the matrix clause is coreferent with the ergative noun phrase in the embedded clause, but 69, where the ergative argument has been fronted with *-ina* on the embedded predicate, is judged as an unacceptable way of describing a scenario where the ergative argument and the possessor are coreferent. In the absence of the offending coreferent pronoun, ergative extraction is grammatical from the embedded clause (70).

(68) E lē mana'o l-o lā'ua$_i$ tinā [e ai [e Talia ma Iosefa]$_i$ sanuisi
PRES not want the-GEN they.DU mother PRES eat ERG Talia and Iosefa sandwich
ia.]]
this.PL
'Their$_i$ mom doesn't want [Talia and Iosefa]$_i$ to eat these sandwiches.'

(69) * O [Talia ma Iosefa]$_i$ e lē mana'o l-o lā'ua$_i$ tinā [e ai**-a**
ALT Talia and Iosefa PRES not want the-GEN they.DU mother PRES eat**-INA**
sanuisi ia].
sandwich this.PL
Intended: 'It is [Talia and Iosefa]$_i$ that their$_i$ mom doesn't want to eat these sandwiches.'

(70) O [Talia ma Iosefa] ou te lē mana'o [e ai-a sanuisi ia].
ALT Talia and Iosefa 1SG PRES not want PRES eat-INA sandwich this.PL

'It's Talia and Iosefa that I don't want to eat these sandwiches.'

The crossover effect in 69 suggests that *-ina* is not interpreted as a base generated pronoun; in fact, the crossover violation may be repaired by inserting an overt pronoun in the ergative position in the embedded clause (71).

(71) O [Talia ma Iosefa]$_i$ e lē mana'o l-o lā'ua$_i$ tinā [**lā** te ai-a
ALT Talia and Iosefa PRES not want the-GEN they.DU mother **3DU** PRES eat-INA
sanuisi ia].
sandwich this.PL
'It is [Talia and Iosefa]$_i$ that their$_i$ mom doesn't want them$_i$ to eat these sandwiches.'

Another scenario where *-ina* contrasts in acceptability with a base generated resumptive may be observed in focus fronting over a *wh*-element. While certain combinations of focus fronted constituent and *wh*-word are grammatical, for example, a focused absolutive theme and a *wh*-fronted ergative agent (72), focus fronting of an ergative agent over a *wh*-element is ungrammatical (73). Similarly to the crossover effect above, the offending configuration may be salvaged with the insertion of a pronoun in the ergative position (74).[24]

(72) O [Lulu ma Iosefa]$_{ABS}$ o ai$_{ERG}$ na fafāgā?
ALT Lulu and Iosefa ALT who PST feed.INA
'Lulu and Iosefa, who fed them?'

(73) * O oe$_{ERG}$ o [ai tamaiti]$_{ABS}$ na fafāgā?
ALT you ALT who children PST feed**.INA**
Intended: 'You, which children did you feed?'

(74) O oe$_{ERG}$ o [ai tamaiti]$_{ABS}$ na **e** fafāgā?
ALT you ALT who children PST **you** feed.INA
'You, which children did you feed?'

While the reasons behind the ungrammaticality of 73 lay outside the scope of this paper, the contrast with 74 reinforces the observation that *-ina* does not behave as a resumptive pronoun which appears in otherwise illicit movement configurations: the predicate in 73 is marked with *-ina*, but the movement dependency is nevertheless ungrammatical, whereas the pronoun in 74 is able to remedy the illicit dependency, presumably by being base-generated in the position of the ergative argument.

[24] The form *fafāgā* 'feed.INA' in 72-74 is derived from the predicate *fafaga* 'feed' by adding *-ina* and elongating the vowel in the penultimate syllable.

To summarize, ergative displacement displays properties typical of a movement dependency despite triggering the appearance of the suffix *-ina*. In this respect, *-ina* contrasts with genuine resumptive pronouns, which may repair illicit displacement. This suggests that there is no ban on ergative displacement in Samoan and the ergative argument need not be analyzed as a PP—a welcome conclusion given that it displays typical subjecthood properties, as discussed in §4.1.

The following subsection presents an alternative analysis of *-ina*, which treats it as a prosodically conditioned transitivity marker rather than a resumptive pronoun. The analysis is particularly supported by configurations with an in situ ergative argument, where *-ina* is nevertheless required.

4.3. THE MORPHOLOGY OF ERGATIVE DISPLACEMENT. This subsection presents an alternative analysis of *-ina*, which does not treat it as a repair for illicit ergative displacement. This suffix has been notoriously difficult to characterize in research on Samoan, so much so that it has been labeled the "mysterious transitive suffix" (Chung 1978; Cook 1978; Mosel 1985).[25] To explain its full range of usages, I argue that *-ina* is a morphosyntactically conditioned exponent of the head which introduces the ergative external argument (Voice^0), and its connection to ergative displacement is merely incidental.

A coherent analysis of *-ina* faces two major challenges. Firstly, while there is a number of contexts where its usage is preferred, there is rarely a categorical requirement for its appearance (see discussion and frequent mention of exceptions to distributional generalizations in Mosel and Hovdhaugen 1992:741-763). In addition to the observation that *-ina* is only compatible with predicates which select an ergative external argument, Mosel and Hovdhaugen (1992) name only two categorical constraints on its usage: *-ina* is obligatory in negative imperatives (75a) and disallowed in positive imperatives (75b); see also Chung 1978; Cook 1988.

(75) a. 'Aua lē lafo***(-ina)** i ai se tusi.
IMPV not send***(-INA)** OBL it.OBL a letter
'Don't send them a letter!'

b. Lafo**(*-ina)** i ai se tusi.
send**(*-INA)** OBL it.OBL a letter
'Send them a letter!' (Chung 1978:91)

Secondly, the constructions which allow or require the appearance of *-ina* only partially form an obvious natural class. As discussed above, *-ina* is robustly associated with contexts where the erga-

[25]To further complicate the picture, it is often grouped together with the suffix *-Cia*, which has a broad range of lexically specified allomorphs (which include *-ina*, *-na*, and *-a*), and is used to mark transitivization and passivization. For example, Mosel and Hovdhaugen (1992:198-204) gloss both *-ina* and *-Cia* as an ergativizing suffix (ES), despite noting distributional differences between them; see also discussion in Chung 1978:81-94; Cook 1988, 1991, 1996.

tive agent undergoes displacement through focus fronting, relativization, and wh-fronting, which are all typical Ā-dependencies. Clitic fronting of ergative arguments also triggers the appearance of *-ina* (60), which is already challenging for a resumption-based analysis due to cliticization being clause-bound and subject-oriented—properties typical of A-movement, which is not expected to be repaired with resumption. The negative imperative context in 75a further challenges any attempt to delineate a natural class of constructions with *-ina*: the ergative agent is typically unexpressed in such constructions, but this is also true for positive imperatives, which categorically disallow *-ina*. Furthermore, the overt use of *-ina* is strongly preferred in negative indicative clauses as well, where it may appear alongside an ergative case-marked ergative DP (76-77). This last type of context is particularly challenging for the resumption-based analysis proposed by Hopperdietzel (2020); Hopperdietzel and Alexiadou (2024, 2025) since the ergative DP has not undergone any obvious displacement.[26] It also means that *-ina* is not an antipassive or otherwise detransitivizing operator, as proposed e.g. by Drummond (2023) for the cognate marker in Nukuoro: clauses with *-ina* continue to exhibit regular ergative-absolutive case marking.

(76) Sā le'i meli**-a** [e le falemeli]**(ERG)** [le tusi](ABS).
PST not mail**-INA** ERG the post office the letter
'The post office didn't deliver the letter.' (Chung 1978:90)

(77) E lē loka***(-ina)** [e leoleo]**(ERG)** [tagata gaoi](ABS).
PRES not lock**-INA** ERG police person steal
'Policemen do not arrest burglars.' (Chung 1978:91)

The remainder of this section presents a sketch of an analysis which (i) incorporates the intuition that *-ina* is rarely categorically required and (ii) explains the seemingly disparate set of constructions where it is preferred or, on the other hand, disallowed or strongly dispreferred. The analysis capitalizes on two properties of this marker: (i) it may only combine with predicates which assign ergative case and (ii) it is a phrasal affix in Anderson's (2005) terminology. This means that, rather than attaching directly to the verbal stem, it attaches at the right edge of the fronted verb phrase following, for example, directional particles, as can be seen in 78 with the appearance of *-ina* triggered by clitic fronting of the ergative subject. This is in contrast, for example, with the historically related passive suffix *-Cia*, which must appear adjacent to the lexical verb, preceding

[26]Hopperdietzel and Alexiadou (2025) note that some speakers allow the co-occurrence of *-ina* with an overt ergative DP in positive declarative sentences. The authors suggest that this is a case of clitic doubling which is associated with focus-related emphasis. The examples they discuss also include a preverbal clitic referring to the same ergative participant, so even under the account here, these would indeed be instances of clitic doubling, which I assume involve the ergative marked DP being either displaced or base generated in a clause-medial position that is associated with contrastive focus, rather than surfacing in situ in its argument position. The negative declarative examples discussed here do not involve a narrow focus interpretation and correspondingly should not be compatible with focus-related clitic doubling, casting doubt on the pronominal analysis of *-ina*.

any other VP-internal elements (79) (Mosel and Hovdhaugen 1992:201). The appearance of *-ina* *after* the verb phrase it modifies is particularly notable given the otherwise robust head initiality of free morphemes in the language: tense, aspect, mood, and all modal auxiliaries precede the verb phrase.[27]

(78) ...ae tasi lava le tagata ia vave ona e [tau mai]-**a**...
but one EMPH the man SUBORD quick C you tell DIR-**INA**
'... but there is one person you should tell us about quickly...' (Mosel and Hovdhaugen 1992:356)

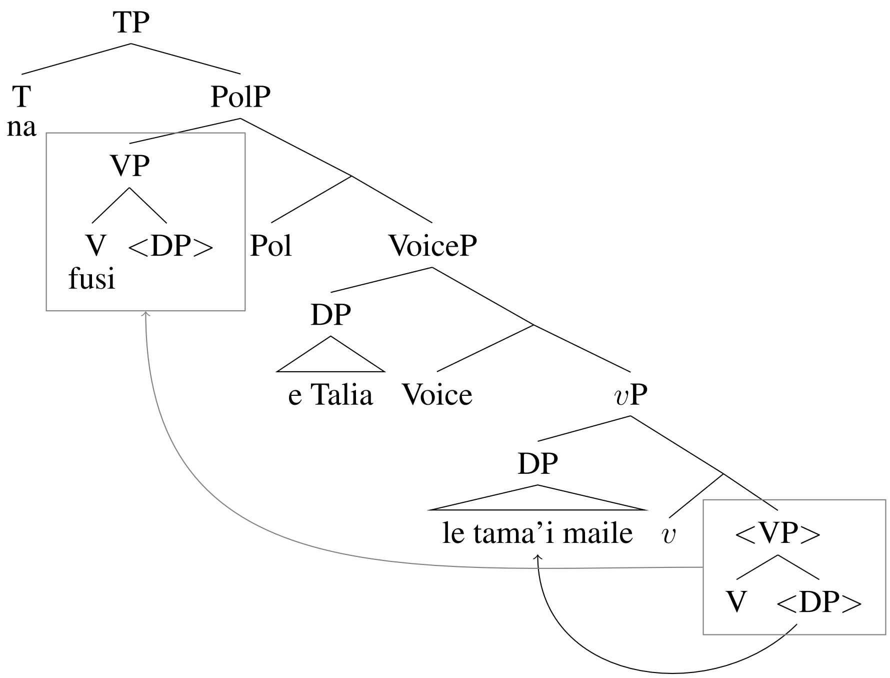
(79) 'Ua [agi-**na** mai] le fu'a.
PERF blow-**CIA** DIR the flag
'The flag is unfurled by the wind.' (Mosel and Hovdhaugen 1992:736)

The proposal is simple: *-ina* is the overt spellout of the head which introduces the ergative agent. Following Tollan (2018), I label this head Voice^0, which selects for vP as its complement and the ergative external argument as its specifier. Based on the extensive argumentation in Collins (2017), Samoan verb initiality is derived through VP fronting to the specifier of a functional head immediately above VoiceP, following the movement of internal arguments to positions outside VP (80). For reasons that will soon become apparent, I label the head which triggers VP fronting Pol for Polarity (Collins 2017 is agnostic about the category of this head, but assumes that the negative particle adjoins to its projection, thus suggesting an association with polarity).

(80) Derivation for 55:

[27] Mosel and Hovdhaugen (1992:743) note that speakers allow for *-ina* to attach after the verb phrase, after the lexical verb, or in both positions. Under the account proposed here this variation can be understood as the result of competing morphosyntactic and morphophonological constraints on affix placement: by default, *-ina* attaches to the edge of the VP, but there is a pressure for it to be pronounced adjacent to the lexical verb, resulting in further displacement or doubling.

(i) a. O ai na fa'atau-a/-ina mai le suka?
ALT who PST buy-INA DIR the sugar
b. O ai na fa'atau mai-a le suka?
ALT who PST buy DIR-INA the sugar
c. O ai na fa'atau-ina mai-a le suka?
ALT who PST buy-INA DIR-INA the sugar
'Who bought the sugar?'

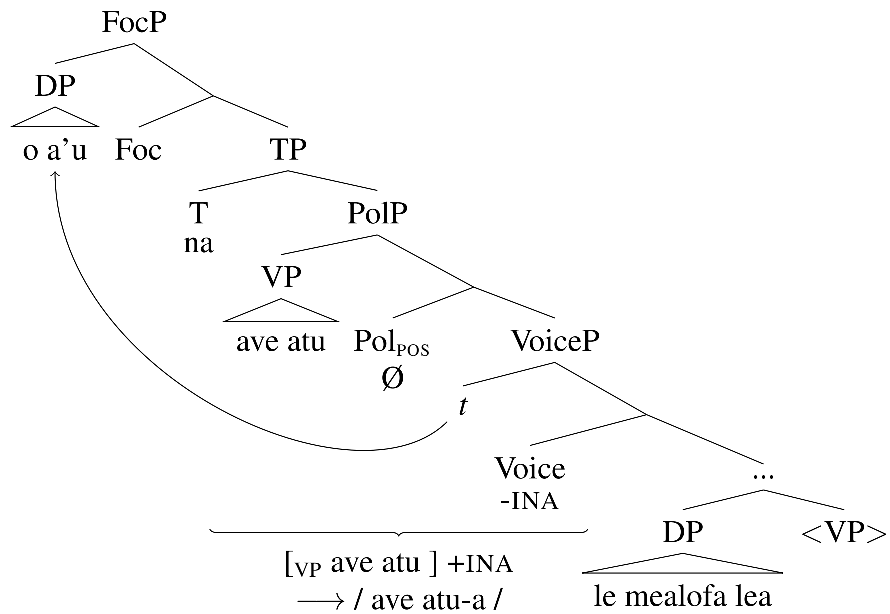


I propose that, as a phrasal affix, Voice^0 attaches to the prosodic constituent immediately to its left and is overtly pronounced as *-ina* or *-a only if* that constituent is the fronted verb phrase. In all other cases, it remains unpronounced. The appearance of this affix is thus only superficially related to displacement of the ergative DP – a morphophonological conspiracy parading as a syntactic generalization. This is illustrated with the contrast between 81 and 83 below. The sentence in 81 involves focus fronting of the ergative DP to the clausal left periphery above T^0 (I assume that it fronts to Spec,FocP, but the specific label of the head is not crucial). Voice^0 is then pronounced as part of the closest overt phrasal constituent on its left – the fronted VP. The result is the overt pronunciation of *-ina*.

(81) Ergative focus fronting: *-ina* is pronounced overtly.

a. O a'u na [$_{\text{VP}}$ ave atu]-a le mealofa lea.
ALT I PST give DIR-INA the gift this
'It was me who gave you this gift.'

b.



To make the interaction between the syntactic category feature on VP (V) and the prosodic component more explicit, I assume that syntactic structure is linearized and mapped to the phonology cyclically. In line with a rich tradition of work on the syntax-phonology interface, I take the relevant structural points for spellout to be phases (Uriagereka 1999; Chomsky 2000, 2001; Fox and Pesetsky 2005; Newell 2008; Dobashi 2013; Sande et al. 2020, *inter alia*). I focus specifically on the spellout domain that includes Voice and the fronted VP—I assume that it roughly corresponds to the complement of C^0 (TP). Most researchers also posit a lower clausal phase: VoiceP or vP. I remain agnostic to the precise position for the lower spellout domain, although if it is VoiceP, then it is important that what is sent to spellout is the complement of the phase head, rather than the full VoiceP (*pace* Bošković 2016), since Voice must remain visible to the phonological component at the next cycle.

In the syntactic component, the category feature of V projects to its maximal projection (VP), determining the syntactic distribution of this constituent. Category-specific phonological effects are common cross-linguistically (Smith 2011; Sande et al. 2020, i.a.), so it is not controversial to assume that this category feature remains visible in the phonological component; I further assume that its ability to project to the VP is mirrored in the prosodic structure by projecting the feature to the corresponding prosodic phrase. As a phrasal affix, *-ina* is prosodically incorporated into the prosodic phrase to its immediate left. Correspondingly, the conditions for the pronunciation of *-ina* can be expressed with the rule in 82: $\text{Voice}_{\text{ERG}}$ is pronounced as *-ina* if it forms part of a prosodic phrase with the category feature V; in all other contexts it remains unpronounced.

(82) a. $[\text{Voice}_{\text{ERG}}] \rightarrow$ /(in)a/ | $(\ X_{[\text{V}]}\ \ldots\ \_\_\ )_{\phi[\text{V}]}$

b. [Voice$_{\text{ERG}}$] $\rightarrow$ Ø | elsewhere

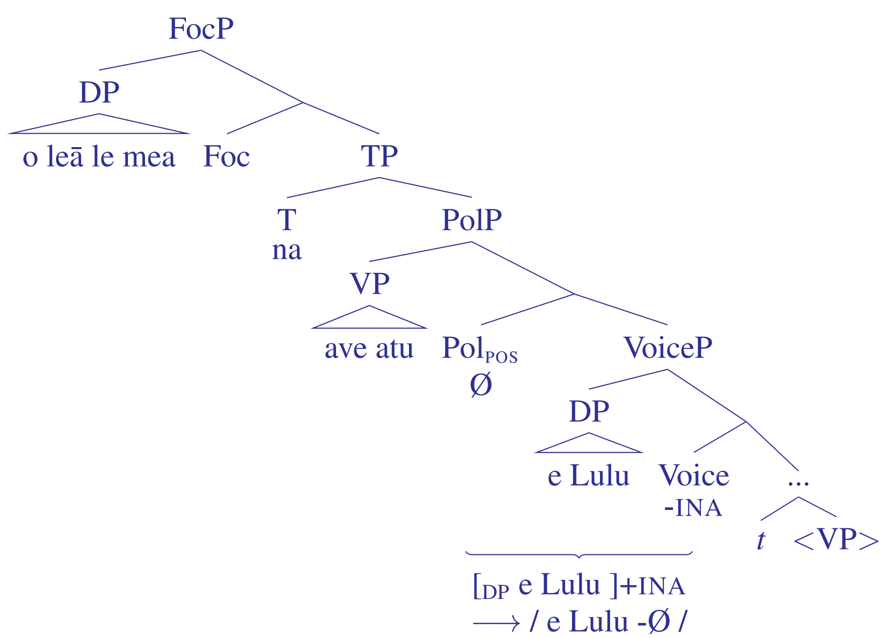
The variability in possible positions for *-ina* inside the VP that is mentioned in footnote 27 may be captured by implementing two competing constraints on the spellout of Voice: one requires Voice$_{\text{ERG}}$ to be pronounced as part of the phonological word which bears [V], i.e. to encliticize to V, whereas the other requires faithfulness to the output of linearization, which places Voice$_{\text{ERG}}$ at the right edge of the full VP.

One context in which Voice^0 remains unpronounced is when the ergative DP remains in situ, as in 83. In this scenario, Voice^0 must be incorporated into the phrasal constituent to its immediate left, which is the DP in its specifier – this does not meet the spellout conditions in 82a and the result is the null allomorph instead of *-ina*.

(83) Ergative DP in situ: *-ina* is not pronounced.

a. O leā le mea na [$_{\text{VP}}$ ave atu] [$_{\text{DP}}$ e Lulu] ?
ALT which the thing PST give DIR ERG Lulu
'What did Lulu give you?'

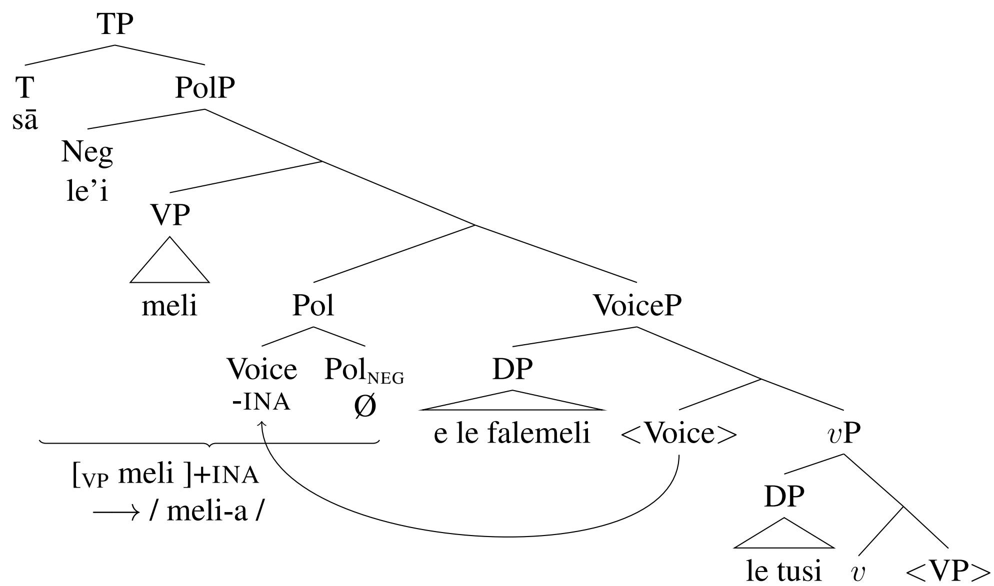
b.



Let us consider how this analysis can account for the remaining configurations where *-ina* may appear. All constructions with ergative displacement are straightforward: the ergative DP is not pronounced in situ, and the exponent of Voice^0 encliticizes to the fronted VP in Spec,PolP, resulting in overt pronunciation of *-ina*, as shown in 81. For those speakers who allow ergative displacement without *-ina*, the null allomorph remains available, albeit dispreferred, in this context. Note that this proposal does not require any additional assumptions about the nature of ergative displacement or a unified analysis for preverbal cliticization and other types of displacement configurations – a desirable conclusion given that pronominal cliticization, unlike any of the other displacement configurations, is clausebound and only available for absolutive subjects of intransitive verbs and ergative external arguments.

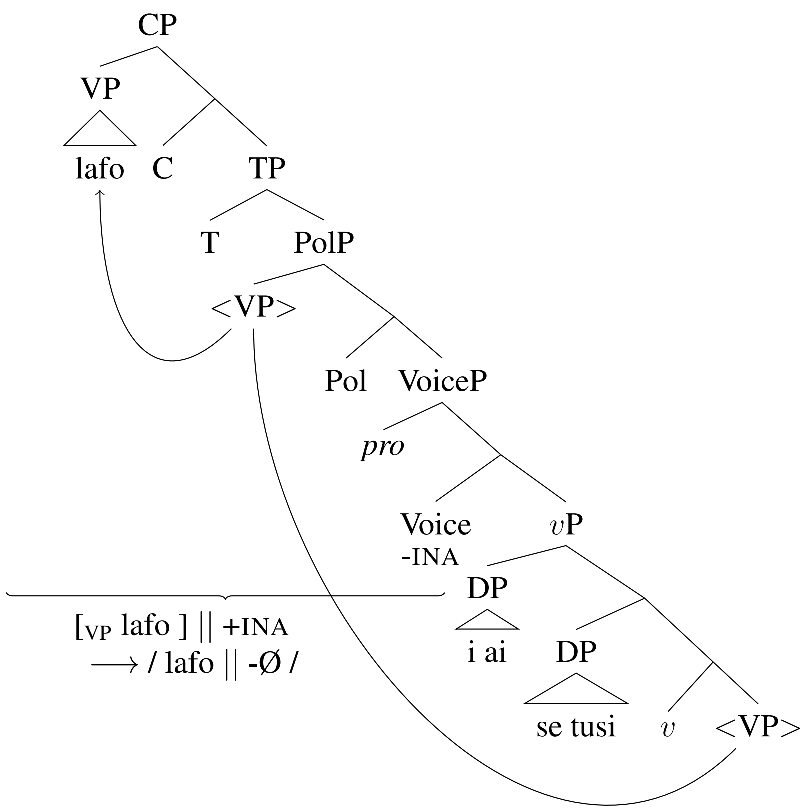
The appearance of *-ina* in negative indicative clauses (76-77), despite the ergative DP appearing in situ, is a result of the negative polarity head (Pol^0) triggering head movement of Voice^0, which correspondingly places *-ina* to the immediate right of the fronted VP in Spec,PolP (84). This is in contrast with the positive polarity head, which does not trigger head movement (83). While there is no independent evidence for this movement, connecting the exponence of *-ina* to the featural properties of the polarity head explains the otherwise puzzling correlation between negation and the overt appearance of *-ina*. Negative polarity allows *-ina* to circumvent the intervening ergative DP and attach to the VP; head movement to Pol^0 is the most straightforward way of achieving this.

(84) Negative Pol triggers head movement of Voice: *-ina* is pronounced overtly.



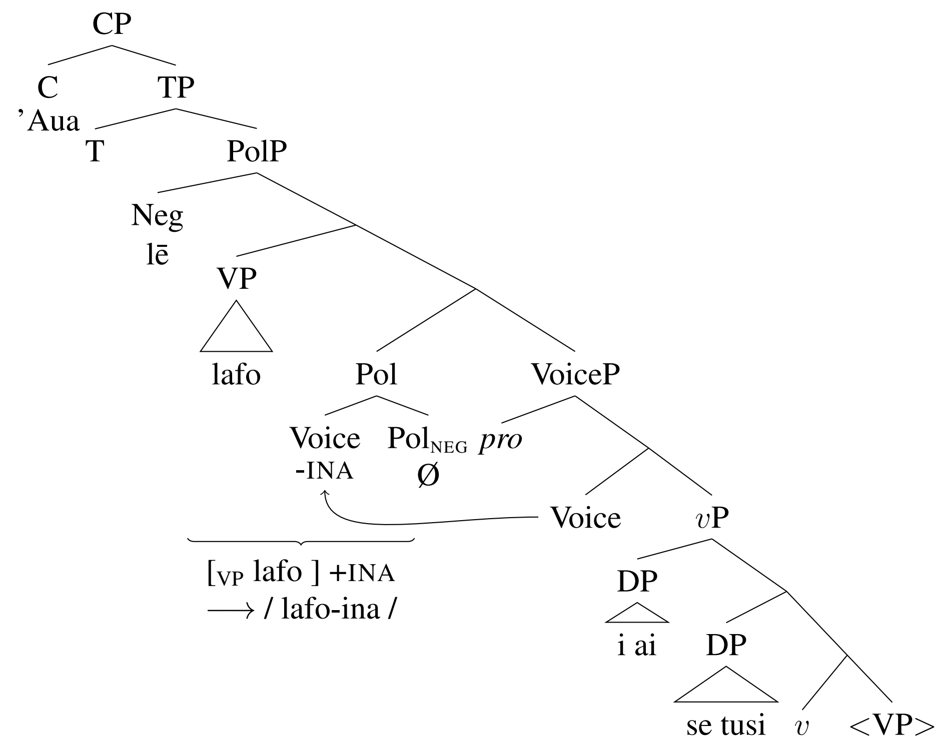
The impossibility of overt *-ina* in imperative clauses is connected to the syntax of imperative clauses. Cross-lingustically, imperatives are often analyzed as involving movement of the lexical verb to a high projection in the left periphery (e.g. Rivero 1994a; Rivero and Terzi 1995; Han 1998, 2001; Zeijlstra 2006, 2013). While the motivation for this movement is not crucial here, I assume following Han (2001) that it is required for the imperative force to take maximally wide scope. In Samoan, the full VP correspondingly undergoes fronting from Spec,PolP to a higher left-peripheral position – I assume here that it is Spec,CP. Research on Samoan prosody suggests that left peripheral material such as focused preverbal constituents form a prosodic phrase which is separated from the remainder of the clause by a phrasal boundary tone (Calhoun 2015)—this suggests that there is indeed a spellout domain which separates the left-peripheral material from the remainder of the clause; as suggested above, I assume that this is the complement of C (TP). When TP is spelled out, there is no appropriate phrasal constituent for Voice to encliticize to, verbal or otherwise, resulting in the application of the elsewhere rule in 82b. The impossibility of *-ina* in positive imperatives is thus connected to the absence of an appropriate constituent within the same prosodic phrase for the morpheme to encliticize to, resulting in the null allomorph.

(85) Structure for 75b: no overt *-ina* because there is a prosodic boundary between VP and Voice^0.



The negative imperative, on the other hand, does not involve VP raising to the left periphery – also a common pattern cross-linguistically. Han (2001) argues that negative imperatives frequently involve a different strategy of marking imperative mood due to a conflict in scope requirements: the imperative operator must scope over the full clause, including negation, whereas negation must scope over the lexical verb (see also Rivero 1994b; Zanuttini 1991, 1994, 1997; Zeijlstra 2004, 2006, *inter alia*). Correspondingly, imperative mood in 75a is expressed with the particle *'aua*, whereas the VP containing the lexical verb remains in Spec,PolP below the negative particle. Similarly to indicative negative clauses, Voice^0 undergoes movement to Pol_{NEG} and successfully encliticizes to the VP in Spec,PolP, resulting in the overt pronunciation of *-ina*.

(86) Structure for 75a: VP remains in Spec,PolP and *-ina* is pronounced overtly.



As previous analyses have argued, there is a direct connection between ergative case and the appearance of the marker *-ina*, but the connection specifically with the displacement of the ergative argument is incidental — it is simply a result of prosodic and morphophonological constraints interacting with differences in syntactic structure: particularly strong support for this comes from negative clauses and imperatives.

To summarize, this subsection argues against a resumption-based analysis of the marker *-ina* which surfaces in cases of ergative displacement in Samoan. I argue instead that this is the exponent of the head which introduces the ergative external argument (Voice^0), which is overt only if it is pronounced in the same prosodic phrase as the fronted VP. Correspondingly, *-ina* is unpronounced when there is phrasal material intervening between Voice^0 and the fronted VP (the in situ ergative DP or scrambled absolutive DP) or when the fronted VP moves out of the spellout domain containing Voice^0, as in positive imperatives. In addition to explaining the appearance of *-ina* when the ergative DP is displaced (and consequently does not intervene between *-ina* and the fronted VP), this analysis is also able to explain the distribution of *-ina* outside of displacement contexts: in negative and imperative clauses. Thus, in the case of Samoan, the appearance of an additional morpheme alongside ergative displacement is not an indication of a syntactic ban on ergative movement – instead, it is a result of the interaction between syntactic structure and rules of syntax-to-prosody mapping.

4.4. MORPHOLOGICAL OR SYNTACTIC ERGATIVITY: SUMMARY. This section has presented evidence that a morphologically marked displacement strategy, such as the use of a resumptive pronoun or a dedicated morpheme on the predicate, does not necessarily entail the presence of a constraint on movement. Both West Circassian (§3) and Samoan display a morphological distinction between absolutive and ergative displacement: the former is unmarked, whereas the latter involves additional morphology—a specialized *wh*-agreement prefix in West Circassian and a verbal suffix in Samoan. However, in both languages ergative displacement passes typical diagnostics for movement: it displays island sensitivity, licenses parasitic gaps, and is sensitive to crossover effects.

The appearance of additional morphology in configurations with ergative displacement is thus not indicative of a syntactic ban on ergative movement. This predicts that the inverse morphological pattern—absolutive displacement triggering additional morphology which is not required with ergative displacement—should also be possible. While typologically more rare, this has indeed been documented in Roviana, an Oceanic language (Collins and Schuelke 2019; Schuelke 2020), and Karitiana, a Tupian language (Storto 1999, 2008; Everett 2006; Vivanco 2014, 2017).[28] Notably, in both languages, absolutive, but not ergative, arguments are encoded with overt morphology in standard declarative clauses: case marking in Roviana and verbal indexing in Karitiana; this overt morphology then alternates with specialized marking when the absolutive argument is extracted. This points towards one of the primary reasons for the appearance of specialized morphology in cases of ergative displacement: in most ergative languages, absolutive case is unmarked and ergative case is marked. Markedness here is understood both in terms of surface morphology and featural markedness. In terms of surface morphology, absolutive case is overwhelmingly expressed by the absence of morphological marking, whereas ergative case is overtly exponed (see e.g. Dixon 1994:11). In terms of featural markedness, most analyses of ergative case systems classify absolutive case as the unmarked member of the paradigm and ergative case as marked, either based on an intrinsic hierarchy of markedness (e.g. Marantz 1991; Woolford 1997, 2006; Legate 2008b; Baker 2014; Deal 2016) or the presence of additional features or structure in ergative case marked constituents (e.g. Deal 2010; Markman and Grashchenkov 2012; Polinsky 2016; Smith et al. 2019; Zompì 2019; Clem 2019; Clem and Deal 2024). Additional morphology in cases of

[28]Thank you to a reviewer for pointing out this prediction and suggesting the references.

ergative displacement is then triggered by the presence of these additional, marked feature values.

For example, Ershova (2021) analyzes the specialized marking which appears in West Circassian relative clauses as the result of ϕ-agreement with a nominal that bears an Ā-feature (following O'Herin 2002 on Abaza and Baier 2018 on the typology of wh-agreement). Assuming that absolutive case is unmarked and the case on ergative and applied arguments is marked, the contrast in exponence can be tied to the presence of a marked case feature on the verbal heads which agree with non-absolutive arguments. This can be the result of case features being transmitted to the agreeing heads alongside ϕ-features, or ϕ-agreement being directly connected to case assignment, as assumed by Ershova (2023b): in that case, the corresponding functional heads are merged with the case features already valued (ERG for Voice^0, OBL for Appl^0, and ABS for T^0). The overt exponent of wh-agreement *zə-* spells out a feature bundle which includes a marked case feature (ERG or OBL), whereas the absence of a marked case feature results in the null exponent for *wh*-agreement with a relativized absolutive argument.

Samoan presents a different type of source for a morphological contrast between ergative and absolutive displacement, which results from ergative agents being introduced by a specialized functional projection (Voice^0). While the allomorphy pattern displayed by Voice^0 in Samoan is language-specific, resulting from the combined ingredients of verb-initiality and the prosodic requirements of this head, the one-to-one correlation between the presence of an ergative argument and this additional functional head increases the probability of similar morphological patterns cross-linguistically, wherein the exponent of Voice^0 depends on whether the ergative DP remains in Spec,VoiceP or undergoes displacement.

In the absence of a reliable connection between patterns of morphological exponence and a syntactic ban on ergative displacement, it is misleading to characterize such patterns as SYNTACTIC ERGATIVITY. In such cases, rules of displacement are not sensitive to the distinction between ergative and absolutive arguments; rather, morphological rules are sensitive to the broader prosodic context (e.g. in Samoan) or the features of the displaced constituent (e.g. in West Circassian). The distinction is purely morphological, hence, such effects would be better characterized as a type of MORPHOLOGICAL ERGATIVITY.

5. IMPLICATIONS AND CONCLUSION. The term SYNTACTIC ERGATIVITY has largely become synonymous with a particular effect: the use of additional morphology in the context of ergative displacement which is absent with absolutive displacement. Traditionally, this type of effect has been explained as a constraint on ergative displacement, and this constraint has been broadly taken to be a universal characteristic of syntactically ergative languages. This paper challenges the consensus position on two counts.

Firstly, I have argued that the universality of the ban on ergative displacement in syntactically ergative languages is theoretically unexpected and empirically incorrect. A syntactically ergative clause structure, wherein the absolutive argument c-commands the ergative agent, cannot reliably rule out ergative displacement, and existing analyses in this vein employ additional parameters to derive the constraint. This is in fact a desirable outcome: West Circassian departs from the existing typology by displaying several syntactic ergativity effects, but allowing for ergative relativization.

West Circassian clearly counters the universal that all syntactically ergative languages display a ban on ergative displacement, but, as the reviewers have pointed out, this does not negate the presence of a strong correlation between high absolutive syntax and constraints on ergative displacement. A closer look at the existing literature, however, does not support a robust typological generalization. The vast majority of literature which connects the ergative extraction constraint with high absolutive syntax focuses on three groups of languages: Mayan (Coon, Mateo, and Preminger 2014; Coon, Baier, and Levin 2021; Tollan and Clemens 2022; Royer 2025; Royer and Coon 2025), Inuit (Bittner and Hale 1996; Yuan 2018, 2022), and Austronesian languages with a Philippine-type voice system (Manning 1996; Aldridge 2004, 2008, 2012). While the high absolutive profile of Mayan languages is additionally supported by binding effects and the absence of absolutive case in nominalizations, as well as the strong correlation between the height of absolutive agreement and the impossibility of ergative displacement, the evidence for high absolutive syntax in Inuit has been recently challenged by Deal et al. (2024), and Austronesian-type voice systems have a long-standing tradition of analysis without any appeal to high absolutive syntax (Rackowski 2002; Rackowski and Richards 2005; Erlewine et al. 2017; Chen 2017, 2025; Chen and McDonnell 2019; Erlewine and Lim 2023, a.o.). Outside of these three language groups, perhaps the best-known example of a language with extensive syntactic ergativity effects in Dyirbal (Dixon 1994), but the strength of that evidence has been challenged by Legate (2008a). Polinsky (2016, 2017), when discussing the robustness of syntactic ergativity across morphologically ergative languages, focuses specifically on the inability of the ergative argument to be extracted "with a gap in the base position" (Polinsky 2016:9)—a pattern that is not taken to be indicative of high absolutive syntax.

Polinsky's (2016:9) definition of syntactic ergativity as "the inaccessibility of ergative arguments to A-bar movement with a gap in the base position" brings us to the second main claim of the paper. The majority of the languages characterized as displaying a ban on ergative extraction in typological surveys such as Polinsky 2016, 2017 are understudied in respect to movement diagnostics, which means that the contrast in morphological exponence between ergative and absolutive extraction is the only observable cue for a syntactic ban on ergative displacement. However, both West Circassian and Samoan challenge the robustness of the connection between contrasts in morphological exponence in displacement contexts and the presence of a syntactic rule which discriminates between ergative and absolutive arguments. For both languages, I have demonstrated that despite ergative extraction triggering specialized morphology, the constructions in question pass typical diagnostics for movement dependencies, suggesting that contrasts in morphological exponence are a superficial, morphological phenomenon, rather than a diagnostic for a syntactic rule. Specifically, I have argued that in West Circassian overt wh-agreement with ergative, but not absolutive, arguments, is connected to ergative case being featurally more marked. In Samoan, on the other hand, the appearance of an additional suffix in configurations with ergative displacement is the result of prosodically conditioned allomorphy of the head which introduces the ergative argument.

In sum, the association between constraints on ergative displacement and ergativity in the syntax is far from straightforward. A language may have a syntactically ergative clause structure and not display a ban on ergative displacement. A language may display a distinct morphological strategy for ergative displacement with it being just that—a morphological pattern, with no underlying constraint on ergative movement. It has also been extensively argued that a language may display a ban on ergative displacement in the absence of high absolutive syntax (Otsuka 2006; Legate 2012; Polinsky 2016; Deal 2016; Drummond 2023; Deal et al. 2024). In such cases, the impossibility of displacement for the ergative argument is usually attributed to its morphological features (ergative case) or structural status as a PP (Polinsky 2016). This suggests that the featural properties of ergative arguments may sometimes result in a contrast in morphological exponence between absolutive and ergative displacement, as in Samoan and West Circassian, or a true ban on ergative movement, as, for example, argued by Legate (2012) for Dyirbal, Drummond (2023) for Nukuoro, and Deal et al. (2024) for Kalaallisut. Finally, there may indeed be high absolutive languages where the high position of the absolutive argument conspires with another grammatical constraint to give rise to a ban on ergative extraction, as in the Mayan languages discussed in §2.

Taken together, these considerations lead to the conclusion that the term SYNTACTIC ERGATIVITY, when used to characterize patterns of ergative displacement, is at best imprecise and at worst misleading. The term would be better utilized as a characteristic for patterns which single out the absolutive argument as in some sense subject-like or—in tree-geometric terms—provide evidence for high absolutive syntax.

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